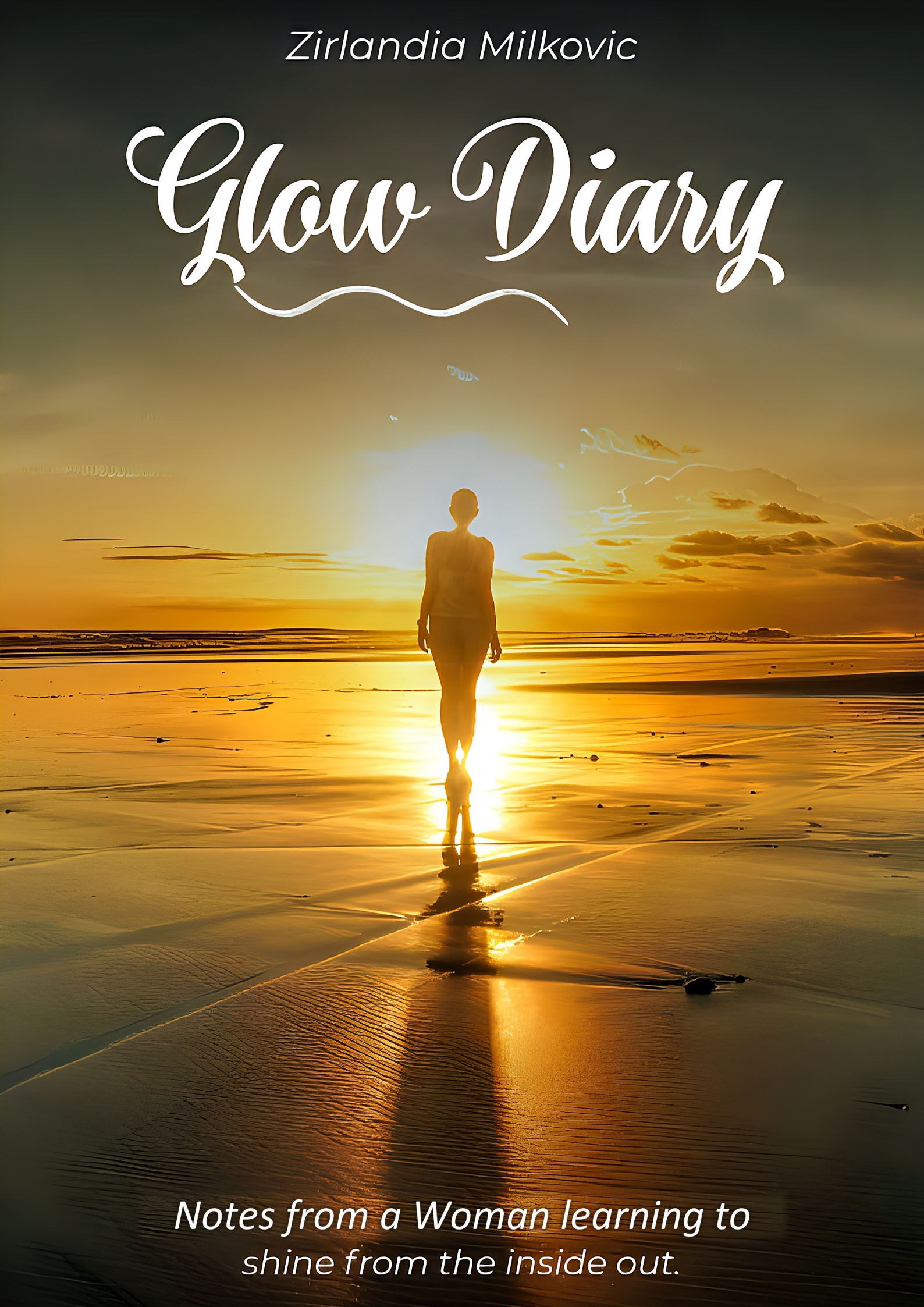
Zirlandia Milkovic

Glow Diary



Notes from a Woman learning to shine from the inside out.

NOTES FROM A WOMAN LEARNING TO SHINE

Glow Diary

Notes from a Woman Learning to Shine from the Inside Out

ZIRLANDIA MILKOVIC

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First edition, 2026.

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This book is for general reflection and personal growth. It is not medical, psychological, financial or legal advice and is not a substitute for professional care. If you are struggling with your mental health, please speak to a qualified professional.

The diary entries, women and situations in these pages are literary composites and fictional illustrations, blended from common experiences. Names and details are invented, and any resemblance to a real person is coincidental. References to research are simplified for general readers.

Nothing here promises a particular outcome. Change is gradual, personal and yours.

For the woman reading this at the end of a long day,

who is still, quietly, on her own side.

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INTRODUCTION

The Day I Realized My Glow Was Missing

Nobody took it. I handed it over in small installments.

FROM THE DIARY

Tuesday, 11:52 p.m.

Bought a serum today that promises to "restore my natural radiance" in fourteen days. I stood in the aisle holding the little box for a full minute, and a strange question arrived, uninvited:

Restore it from where?

Because I couldn't remember the last time I felt lit from the inside. Not pretty. Not put-together. Lit. The way you feel at nineteen on the first warm night of the year, when nothing has been decided yet and you are simply glad to be alive and in your own skin.

I paid for the serum anyway. But I've been lying here for an hour thinking about that word. Restore. As if someone took it. As if there were a thief.

There wasn't a thief. I'm starting to suspect it was me.

That was the night this book began, though I didn't know it yet. I thought I was having a small, slightly embarrassing moment in a pharmacy. It turned out to be the first honest conversation I'd had with myself in years.

Here is what I had been telling everyone, including me: *I'm fine. I'm just busy.* And it was true, in the way that a lot of things are true and still not the whole story. I was busy. I was capable. People would have described me as "so together." I answered messages quickly, remembered birthdays, hosted, helped, showed up. My calendar was full and my face was pleasant.

But something had gone quiet. The part of me that used to get excited about small things, that had opinions about music and light and what to do with a Sunday, had gone so still that I had stopped noticing the silence. I had traded her in, one reasonable compromise at a time, for a woman who was easy to live with, easy to rely on, and very difficult to know.

That is the woman I want to talk about. Not because she's broken. Because she is far more common than any of us admit, and because almost nobody tells her the truth: that the fix is not another version of her, polished and improved. **It is the return of the one she already was.**

Your glow is not something you put on. It is something you uncover.

What I mean by "glow"

Let me be careful with that word, because the beauty industry has spent a long time selling it back to us in bottles.

I do not mean flawless skin, a curated kitchen, or a face that photographs well in morning light. I mean something much older and much harder to fake: the visible ease of a woman who is in relationship with herself. You know it when you see it. It's the friend who takes up exactly the room she needs. The colleague who says "I don't know, let me find out" without flinching. The woman at the next table who laughs with her whole face and doesn't check who noticed.

That glow isn't a product of perfect circumstances. Some of the most luminous women I have met were in the middle of divorces, career collapses, grief, or a very unglamorous rebuild. What they had in common was not that life was easy. It was that they had stopped abandoning themselves in order to keep the peace.

What this book is, and isn't

This is not a book about becoming perfect, more impressive, or more acceptable to other people. There is no five-step formula in here, no promise that you will transform in seven days. I don't believe in those promises, and I suspect you don't either, or you wouldn't have picked up a book that calls itself a diary.

What it is: a sequence of honest evening conversations. Each chapter opens with a page from a private diary, moves through a story or two, some plain-spoken psychology, and a few practical things to actually do. At the end of each chapter you'll find the same small landmarks:

Glow Note, a sentence to carry. **Real Talk**, where I say the thing that's slightly uncomfortable. **Journal Moment**, questions to sit with. **Glow Practice**, one exercise you can genuinely complete. **Remember This**, a line for the hard days.

The women in these pages are composites and fictions, their names invented and their details blended. But the feelings are not invented. I have yet to meet a reader who didn't recognize at least one of them and think, with a mix of relief and irritation, *oh. That's me.*

How to read it

Slowly, if you can. Not because it's difficult, but because you'll want to stop. Keep a pen nearby. Write in the margins of the pages you agree with and, more usefully, the ones that annoy you. Annoyance is often just a truth arriving before we're ready to sign for it.

You don't have to begin at the beginning, but I'd gently suggest you do. The chapters follow a path: from noticing that something is missing, to understanding what has been draining you, to listening to yourself again, to protecting what you rebuild, to becoming the kind of woman who can stay. It is not a fast road. It is a real one.

THE PATH THIS DIARY FOLLOWS

BEGINNING
I don't know who I am anymore.

AWARENESS
I understand what has been draining me.

RECONNECTION
I am beginning to hear myself again.

BOUNDARIES
I don't have to abandon myself to keep others.

CONFIDENCE
I can trust myself.

INDEPENDENCE
I can build a life that belongs to me.

ACCEPTANCE
I don't need to be perfect.

TRANSFORMATION
I am becoming the woman I was always capable of being.

COMING HOME
My glow comes from knowing who I am.

Somewhere in the pharmacy aisle that Tuesday, a very quiet voice said: you haven't been restored yet because you haven't been found. I didn't answer it for a long time. This book is what I eventually said back.

Come and sit down. Put the kettle on. Let's talk.



CHAPTER ONE

When You Stop Recognizing Yourself

How women lose themselves quietly, politely, and one reasonable compromise at a time.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

Somebody asked what kind of music I like today, and I said "oh, anything, really." Which is a lie, and a strange one, because I have opinions. I used to have very strong opinions. I used to argue about the second album.

I think I say "anything" so often now that it has become true. Nobody can disappoint me if I never choose. Nobody can be inconvenienced.

I looked at my playlist tonight. It is a museum of other people's tastes: what my partner plays in the car, what my sister recommended, what was "good for focus." I scrolled for a while trying to find me in it.

I'm still scrolling.

There is a particular kind of loneliness that has nothing to do with being alone. It happens in a full house, a busy office, a friendship group where everyone adores you, and it sounds like this: no one here knows what I actually want, including me.

Women rarely lose themselves in a single dramatic moment. That's what makes it so difficult to notice. There is no betrayal to point at, no day you can circle on the calendar. It happens the way a shoreline disappears: not with a crash, but with a slow, polite tide.

You say yes to the plan you didn't want, because the other person was excited. You soften an opinion because the room got tense. You drop the hobby because there isn't time, and there isn't time because you've filled the time with everyone else's needs. You start answering "what do you want for dinner?" with "whatever's easiest for you," and eventually you stop being able to answer it at all.

None of these moments is a mistake. Each one, taken alone, is kind, sensible, even generous. That's the trap. **You can't spot the drift by examining any single decision, only by looking up one day and realizing the coastline has moved.**

The roles that swallow the woman

We are handed roles early: the reliable one, the pretty one, the smart one, the easy one, the strong one. Later come the grown-up versions: partner, mother, daughter, manager, friend who always has it together. Roles are not the enemy. They give life structure and meaning. The problem starts when the role stops being something you *do* and becomes something you *are*, and there is no one left underneath it to ask what she needs.

A woman who has been "the strong one" for a decade doesn't only carry heavy things. She loses permission to be tired. A woman who has always been "the easy one" learns, without anyone saying it, that having a preference is a form of trouble.

A STORY

Marielle and the Bookshop

Marielle, thirty-eight, had spent her whole adult life being wonderful to live with. She was the one who remembered the allergy, brought the extra chair, found the compromise. Then one rainy Saturday, alone for the first time in months, she walked into a bookshop with an hour to herself and stood frozen in the middle of the fiction section.

She didn't know what she wanted to read. She didn't mean she couldn't decide between two books. She meant that when she asked herself, honestly, *what do I feel like?* there was only static. For years she had chosen what the people around her would enjoy, or approve of, or find impressive when she mentioned it. She had never needed a taste of her own.

She left with nothing and cried in the car, embarrassed at how much a bookshop had undone her.

The following Saturday she went back and bought the first novel whose cover made her feel something, even though she couldn't have explained why. It turned out to be mediocre. She didn't finish it. But that small, wobbly act of choosing something for no reason other than *I was drawn to it* was the first time in years she had heard her own voice. She wrote it down that evening. It was a very short entry: *I picked. It was bad. I picked.*

BEHIND THE FEELING

What psychologists call "self-concept clarity"

Psychologists use the term *self-concept clarity* for how clearly and consistently you know your own preferences, values and traits. Research tends to link lower clarity with more difficulty making decisions and a shakier sense of wellbeing, which fits what so many women describe: the fog, the "I don't know what I want" that is not indecision at all, just an unused muscle.

The encouraging part is that clarity isn't fixed. It rebuilds the way it eroded, through small, repeated acts of noticing and choosing. Not through a sweeping soul-search on a mountaintop, but through a thousand tiny data points: *I like this. I don't like that. That made me tense. That made me laugh.*

How to hear yourself again

Begin far smaller than you think you should. Big questions like "who am I?" and "what is my purpose?" are too large to answer when the self has been quiet for a while. They invite either panic or performance. Start with preferences so small they feel almost silly, because small is exactly the point. Small is safe. Small can be practiced on a Tuesday.

Notice your **automatic replies**. When someone asks what you'd like, watch for "I don't mind" or "whatever works." You're not being told off for saying them; you're simply learning how often you do. Next, pause for three seconds before answering and check whether a real preference is hiding there. Often it is, and it's tiny: *actually, I'd love the window seat. I'd rather have the pasta.* Say the small thing out loud. Nothing collapses.

And begin, gently, to pay attention to your **body's data**. The tightening in the chest when you agree to something you don't want. The lift when a conversation goes somewhere you care about. The tiredness that arrives when you've spent an afternoon being someone you're not. Your body has been keeping the accurate records the whole time.

REAL TALK

You did not lose yourself in one dramatic betrayal. You lost yourself in a few thousand convenient yeses, and some of them were your idea. That isn't blame. It's good news, because what you gave away in installments you can begin collecting back the same way.

GLOW NOTE

You don't need to become someone else to become more yourself.

REMEMBER THIS

Feeling like a stranger to yourself is not proof that something is wrong with you. It is proof that you have been paying attention to everyone else.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- When did I last answer a question about what I wanted, honestly and without softening it?
- Which role am I performing so well that I've forgotten I'm allowed to step out of it?
- What did I love at fifteen, or twenty-two, that I quietly stopped making room for?
- Which small "I don't mind" could become a real preference this week?

WRITE IT HERE

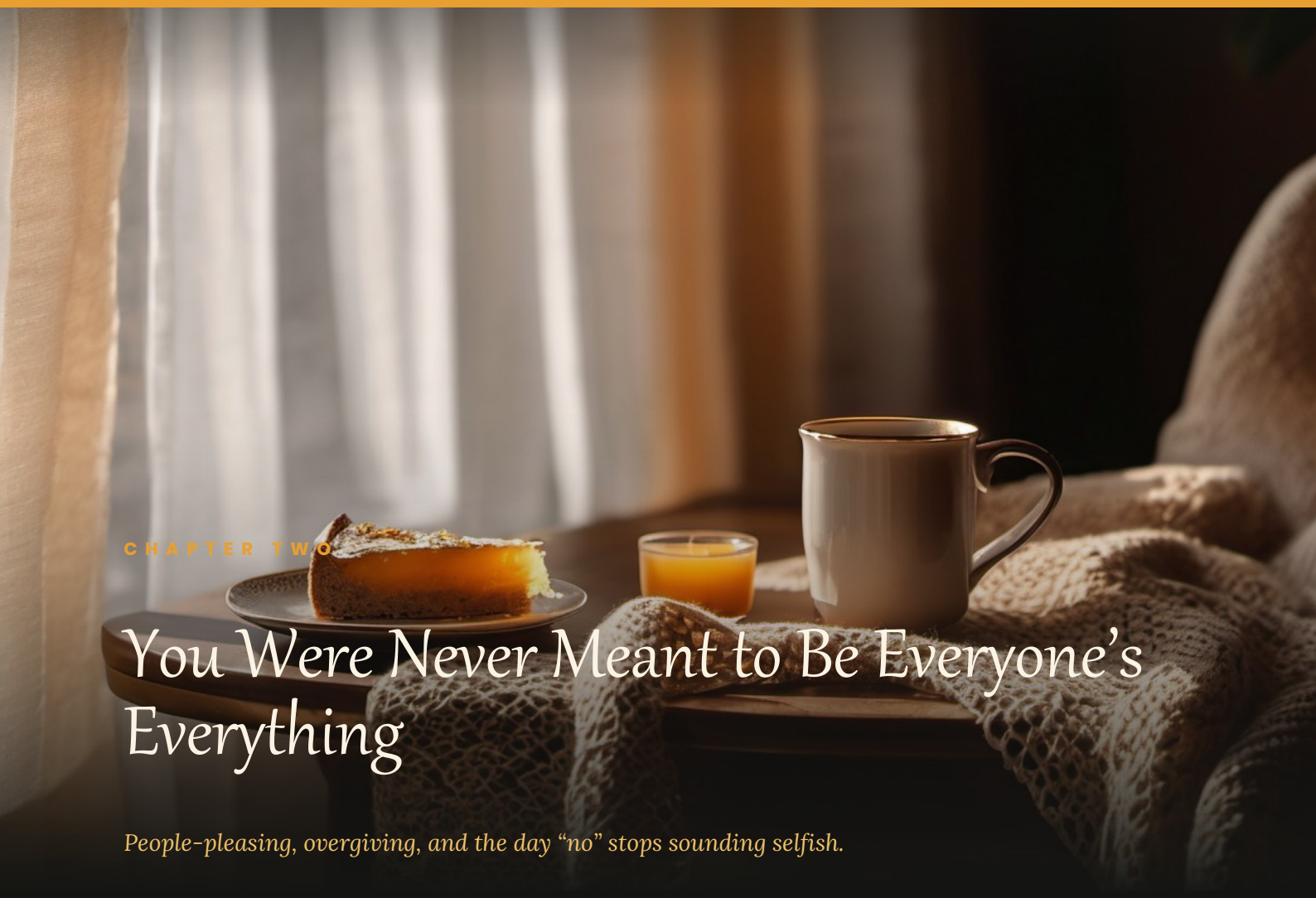
GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Ten Small Preferences

For seven days, keep a note on your phone or in the back of this book titled **"Things I actually like."** Each time you notice a genuine pull or aversion, however tiny, write it down without justifying it: *the yellow mug. Silence in the car. Not being called after nine. Walking the long way home.* Aim for ten by the end of the week.

Don't analyze them and don't share them yet. Let them be evidence. You're not building a personality; you're re-acquainting yourself with the one that's been waiting.

Somewhere beneath the roles and the reasonable compromises, she is still there. She's a little out of practice, perhaps a little shy of the light. But she hasn't gone anywhere. She has simply been waiting, with remarkable patience, for someone to ask her a question and to actually listen to the answer.



CHAPTER TWO

You Were Never Meant to Be Everyone's Everything

People-pleasing, overgiving, and the day "no" stops sounding selfish.

FROM THE DIARY

Sunday, 9:40 p.m.

Tonight I said "of course, no problem!" to four separate requests before dinner. I counted afterwards, the way you count the drinks after a bad night.

One was a favor I didn't have time for. One was an invitation I dreaded. One was covering for someone who, honestly, will not cover for me. One was a "quick call" that will not be quick.

I have a smile ready for all of these. It is very well practiced. It appears before I've had a chance to consult the rest of me.

The strange part is that nobody asked me to be like this. Nobody is holding a stopwatch. I am the one exhausted by a standard that I invented, enforce, and then resent.

I'm so tired I could lie down on the kitchen floor. I'm going to try to remember that feeling tomorrow, when the smile arrives early again.

Let's start with a kind of confession that most women find easier to make in the dark: I am tired of being nice.

Not tired of being kind. Kindness is a quality of character, a choice, and it gives back as much as it takes. What wears us down is something that looks almost identical from outside but runs on completely different fuel. It is niceness as a survival strategy. Agreeableness as insurance. Helpfulness offered not from abundance but from a low, constant hum of *please don't be upset with me.*

Psychologists call this **people-pleasing**, and it is not a personality flaw so much as an old solution to an old problem. Somewhere along the way, most of us learned that being useful, pleasant and low-maintenance was the safest way to be loved. It worked. That is exactly why it's so hard to put down.

The invisible cost of being easy

Here's what nobody mentions at the start: people-pleasing pays out, and generously. You're praised as reliable. You're described as "an angel." You are the first person anyone thinks of when there's a need. All of that feels very much like being loved.

But look closely at what's being rewarded. It isn't you. It's your *output*. And that creates a quietly terrible arrangement in which your worth feels conditional on your usefulness, so the only way to feel secure is to be more useful still.

The word for the resulting state is **overgiving**, giving past your own capacity and then resenting it, usually silently and usually in the direction of the people you love most. The sociologist Arlie Hochschild coined the term *emotional labor* decades ago to describe the work of managing your own feelings, and others', to keep a situation smooth. Many women perform this all day long: at work, in friendships, in families. Nobody pays for it, nobody schedules it, and nobody notices until it stops.

A STORY

Lena Learns a Small, Terrible Word

Lena, thirty-one, was the family organizer. Every birthday, every holiday, every "we should really get everyone together" landed with her. That December her mother announced, cheerfully, that the whole family would gather at Lena's apartment for the third year running, and asked what Lena thought she'd like to cook.

Lena opened her mouth to say "sounds lovely," as she always did, and heard herself say instead, *"I can't host this year. I'd love to come, though."*

The silence on the phone was the longest of her life. Her mother said, "Oh," in a small voice. Lena spent the next two days composing apologies she did not send. Her sister called to say she was being "a bit dramatic." For a week she was sure she had wrecked something permanent.

She hadn't. The family gathered at her sister's house, a little chaotically. Lena brought a dessert and left before the washing-up. It was not a triumphant scene. Her mother was noticeably cool for a month. But something had shifted that Lena couldn't put back: she now knew that a "no" could be survived. Not painlessly, not without a sulk or two. But survived.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Guilt is a signal, not a verdict

When you begin saying no after years of saying yes, you will feel guilty. This is not proof you've done something wrong. It's proof you've broken a pattern, and patterns push back. Guilt, in this situation, is often the discomfort of *changing the deal* rather than an accurate reading of harm.

A useful question: **"Am I feeling guilty because I did something unkind, or because I disappointed someone?"** Those are different things. You are allowed to disappoint people. It is an unavoidable part of having a self.

Saying no without a lecture

You do not need a long justification. In fact, the longer the explanation, the more it becomes an invitation to negotiate. Consider three plain, kind formulas:

The clean no. "I can't take that on. Thank you for thinking of me."

The not-now. "I can't do this week. I could look at it in March."

The counter-offer. "I can't host, but I'd love to bring the main dish."

Notice what all three have in common: warmth, clarity, and no apology for having limits. You can be gracious *and* unavailable. Those two things get along beautifully.

The pause is your friend

If your yes arrives faster than your thinking, buy yourself time. **"Let me check and get back to you"** is one of the most quietly powerful sentences in the language. It interrupts the reflex. It lets you consult the rest of yourself, the tired part, the part with a to-do list, the part that actually wants the weekend. Most requests do not need an answer in the next four seconds. Practise the pause on low-stakes things first, and let the muscle strengthen before you use it on the big ones.

REAL TALK

Some of what you call generosity is actually fear wearing a nice cardigan. It's worth asking who you'd be if being needed were not the only way you knew to be welcome.

GLOW NOTE

A yes that costs you your peace is a loan, and you will be repaid in resentment.

REMEMBER THIS

Saying no is not the opposite of love. It is what makes your yes worth something.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Whose disappointment do I fear most, and what am I afraid it will mean?
- Which recurring request do I always say yes to while quietly dreading it?
- What would I do with an extra two hours a week if I stopped saying yes automatically?
- Where did I first learn that being useful was the safest way to be loved?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The 24-Hour Rule

For one week, don't answer any non-urgent request on the spot. Use one of these: **"Let me check and get back to you."** or **"I'll think about it and let you know by tomorrow."** Then actually consult yourself. Ask three things: *Do I want to? Do I have the capacity? What would I be saying no to by saying yes?*

Keep a tally of how many times you said yes after the pause, and how many times you changed your answer. You are gathering information about your own limits, not testing your willpower.

The woman who can't say no is not a weak woman. She is often the strongest one in the room, carrying more than anyone has seen. The invitation of this chapter is not to become less generous, but to become generous on purpose, from a full cup and with an open hand, rather than from an emptied one and clenched fists.



CHAPTER THREE

The Mirror Has Nothing to Do With Your Worth

Beauty, aging, comparison, and finally separating how you look from who you are.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

I looked at myself in the fitting room mirror today, under those unforgiving lights, and I had a conversation with my own reflection that I would never have with another woman.

I said things to my thighs that I wouldn't say to a stranger's dog.

Afterwards I stood outside the store and felt genuinely stunned. Not by what I'd seen, but by what I'd said. Where did I learn that voice? When did it move in? And why, after all these years, does it still get to review me every time I pass a store window?

I want to be gentler than that. I don't yet know how. But writing down what she says feels like a start. It looks a lot smaller on paper.

Most women can remember the exact moment they first understood that their body was something to be evaluated. It might have been a comment from a relative, a magazine cover, a boy at school, a doctor's offhand remark, a swimming costume in a store. Whatever the source, a switch flipped: I am not only living in this body; I am being looked at in it.

From that day on, many of us developed a second mind, a running internal commentator. Its opinions are constant, specific and unfailingly harsh. It notices the arm in the photograph. It doubles the size of what it sees. It quietly determines whether you'll go to the beach, wear the dress, accept the invitation.

If this is you, you are extremely normal, and you have also been carrying a heavy and unnecessary load.

The most expensive lie

The lie is that your appearance is a measure of your value, and that improving one will automatically improve the other. It's a very good lie, because it's constantly reinforced: in advertising, in social feeds, in the way strangers talk about women who are aging or gaining weight or simply not performing prettiness.

It is also *profitable*. An entire economy depends on you feeling just slightly not-enough about your face, your skin, your hair, your shape, and it will happily sell you a fresh remedy every season. This doesn't make wanting to look and feel good shameful. I love a good haircut and a beautiful coat. But there's a world of difference between **adornment as pleasure** and **adornment as apology.**

One asks, *what do I feel like wearing today*? The other asks, *how do I make myself acceptable*?

A STORY

Ana and the Feed

Ana, twenty-nine, was not unhappy with her life. She had a job she was decent at, good friends, a small apartment with a lemon tree on the balcony. Then she started noticing that after twenty minutes on her phone, she felt worse. Not sad, exactly. *Reduced.* Everyone she followed seemed to be gliding through a slightly better version of existence: better skin, better holiday, a more graceful way of holding a coffee cup.

She knew, rationally, that it was curated. She'd said so to friends, wisely, at dinner. But knowing didn't stop the drop in her stomach. One evening she counted: forty-five minutes of scrolling, and she'd mentally edited her body, her apartment, her salary and her life.

She didn't delete every app in a burst of resolve. She did something more modest and, over time, more effective. She muted forty accounts that made her feel small, followed a few that made her feel curious rather than inadequate, and set a rule: no scrolling in bed. Within a month she noticed she'd stopped narrating her own appearance to herself quite so often. Some evenings she slipped back. Progress, she decided, was allowed to be wobbly.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Why comparison feels so automatic

In the 1950s, psychologist Leon Festinger proposed *social comparison theory*: humans evaluate themselves by comparing to others, especially when there's no objective measure. It's a normal, built-in process. Feeds simply give it an unprecedented supply: a constant stream of other people's best angles, at a scale no human brain was built for.

You can't turn comparison off. But you can change what you feed it. Curate the input the way you'd curate what you put on your plate.

Aging is not a failure

We are the first generation of women to be told, relentlessly, that aging is optional, that with enough serums, procedures and vigilance we might defeat it. The message underneath is cruel: that a woman's face at fifty is evidence of her *negligence*.

Look around at the women you actually admire. I'd bet they are not the ones who look twenty-five. They're the ones who look **like themselves**, with expressions worn in by real laughing and real thinking, who move through rooms as though they've decided to be at home in them. That is not the absence of aging. It's the presence of self.

You are allowed to care for your skin, dye your hair or leave it gray, have work done or not. What you are not obligated to do is treat your own passing years as a personal failing.

Three ways to loosen the mirror's grip

Move for how it feels, not how it looks. Walk, dance, lift, stretch: whatever leaves you feeling *inhabited*. When the goal shifts from shrinking to feeling strong and alive, the relationship with the body starts to soften.

Speak to your reflection as you would to a friend. It sounds twee. It is also a genuine practice. Notice the harsh sentence, then ask: *would I say this to someone I love*? If not, rewrite it. You're not lying to yourself; you're refusing to be cruel.

Collect evidence of what your body does, not just how it looks. It carried you through last week, laughed at that joke, hugged the person you love, got you up the hill. Your body is not decoration. It is your home and your instrument.

REAL TALK

You can't hate yourself into a version you'll finally be able to love. Contempt has never been a good coach. The women who look after their bodies best are, almost always, the ones who stopped punishing them first.

GLOW NOTE

Your body is where you live, not something you are on trial in.

REMEMBER THIS

The mirror shows you a surface. It has never had access to the rest of the story.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Whose voice do I actually hear when I criticize my body? Whose was it first?
- What do I stop myself from doing because of how I think I look?
- Which accounts, magazines or people leave me feeling smaller, and which leave me feeling more like myself?
- What is one thing my body did this week that I am grateful for?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Kind Mirror

Once a day for two weeks, stand in front of a mirror for one minute, clothed or not, whichever you can manage. Say aloud **three things your body or face has done for you** ("These legs got me through that hill." "This mouth told the truth today."), then name **one thing you find genuinely lovely**, even if it's your left eyebrow.

It will feel awkward on day one. By day ten, the harsh commentator will have a competitor.

There is a version of you that isn't waiting to be thinner, younger, more polished or better lit before she starts living. She is already standing in this body, on this date, in this life. She's the one who has been doing all the walking. Perhaps it's time she was thanked.



PART TWO

Rebuilding

She stopped asking for the map and started trusting her feet.



CHAPTER FOUR

The Confidence You Keep Looking for Is Already Being Built

Confidence isn't a feeling you find. It's a track record you keep.

FROM THE DIARY

Tonight I realized...

...that I have been waiting to feel confident before doing the things that would make me confident. Which is a bit like waiting to be strong before lifting anything.

I thought confidence was a personality type. Some people got the "bold" package, and I received the "conscientious, slightly apologetic" one. I've been quietly grieving that for about fifteen years.

But today I did the thing I was dreading. Asked for a meeting. Said what I actually thought in the first two minutes instead of the last. My voice shook. Then I went to the bathroom, looked in the mirror, and thought: I did it while scared. And that felt more like confidence than any of the fake calm I've ever produced.

Write that down. Shaking voice, still said it.

Ask a room of women what they'd most like to have more of, and confidence will come up almost every time. It's the thing they imagine other women possess, some luminous internal certainty that makes speaking up effortless and setbacks bearable.

The reality is much less mystical, and much more encouraging. Confidence is not a mood or a personality type. It is a **record**. It's what accumulates when you do difficult things, survive them, and learn from the result. Psychologists who study self-belief describe something close to this: Albert Bandura's work on *self-efficacy*, the belief in your ability to handle specific challenges, found that the strongest source of that belief is *mastery experiences*: the times you actually did the thing and it worked, or at least didn't destroy you.

In other words, the confident woman across the room isn't more gifted than you. She's usually just further along the pile of evidence.

Why waiting doesn't work

We hold a persistent, quietly damaging assumption: *I'll do it once I feel ready.* Ready to apply, ready to speak, ready to start the business, end the relationship, make the move. But feeling ready is usually the **result** of action, not the precondition for it. If you wait for the feeling, you can wait years, because the feeling requires the very experience you're delaying.

There's also a subtle trap on the other side: **overpreparation**. Researching, planning and perfecting can feel productive, but often it's fear in a business suit. It gives you the sensation of progress without the risk of being seen doing the thing imperfectly.

> Confidence is the trust that builds when you keep the promises you make to yourself.

The four builders of confidence



Action. The smaller, slightly scary thing. Not the giant leap; the next step. Send the email. Ask the question. Book the appointment.

Evidence. Noticing what actually happened. Most of us do a brave thing and then instantly dismiss it, so evidence never accrues. Keep a *proof file*: a note on your phone where you log moments you did something hard anyway. When your inner critic says "you can't," you'll have receipts.

Trust. Here's where confidence quietly forms. Every time you say "I'll do it" and do it, you strengthen your own credibility with yourself. Break enough of those promises and you stop believing yourself. Keep enough and something steadies.

Competence. Confidence loves skill. Get good at something that matters to you, and let yourself be visibly a beginner along the way. Being new at something is not a sign that you're inadequate. It's a sign that you're still growing.

A STORY

Noor Starts Again at Thirty-Nine

Noor spent fifteen years in hospitality management, then decided, at thirty-nine, to retrain as a UX designer. Her first month was humbling. Classmates fifteen years younger moved through software with a fluency she found infuriating. In week three she cried in a stairwell.

She stayed, but not through a sudden burst of belief. She stayed through a very ordinary system: each evening, she wrote down one thing she'd learned that she couldn't do the week before. *Used the pen tool without googling. Explained my wireframe without apologizing.* By month four the list was long enough to argue with her doubts. By month eight she got a junior role, less senior and less well paid than her old one, and felt slightly wobbly about it.

She wasn't magically certain. She still froze before presentations. But she'd stopped mistaking the freeze for proof she didn't belong there. She had a file that said otherwise.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Imposter feelings and the evidence gap

The sense of being a fraud who's about to be found out is remarkably common, particularly at moments of stretch or transition. It isn't a diagnosis; it's a description of a gap between how capable you are and how capable you *feel*. Closing the gap doesn't mean arguing yourself out of the feeling. It means giving your mind more current, specific evidence than it currently has, and giving it time to update.

Everyday confidence, in practice

Speak a little earlier than feels comfortable. In meetings, the wish to wait for the perfect moment often means waiting until someone else says it. Offer the thought while it's still yours.

Keep the tiny promises. If you say you'll walk for ten minutes, walk for ten minutes. If you say you'll send the email by four, send it by four. Small kept promises are the bricks of self-trust.

Take up your actual space. Posture, pace, a slower voice: not tricks to fool people, but ways of telling your own nervous system it's allowed to be here.

Treat mistakes as data. A mistake tells you what didn't work *this time*. It does not deliver a verdict on who you are.

REAL TALK

Nobody is coming to hand you confidence in a nicely wrapped box. And the confident women you envy? Most of them still get nervous. They just stopped treating nervousness as a stop sign.

GLOW NOTE

You don't have to feel brave. You only have to be brave once, and then keep the receipt.

REMEMBER THIS

A shaking voice that says the true thing is more powerful than a calm one that stays silent.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Where am I waiting to feel ready before I move?
- What is the smallest brave thing I could do this week, and what would make it easier to actually do?
- Which promises to myself have I been breaking, and which ones would I like to start keeping?
- What is on my “proof list” already that I haven’t given myself credit for?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Proof File

Create a note on your phone titled **”Proof.”** Every evening for two weeks, add one line: something you did that took a little courage, or a little discipline, or a little skill. Don’t judge its size. *Said no politely. Started the spreadsheet. Wore the red lipstick.*

At the end of two weeks, read the whole thing aloud. Notice how your voice sounds reading it. That is what you’ve been becoming.

Confidence is not a place you arrive; it’s a habit of trust you build, brick by ordinary brick. You’re already laying them. It only feels invisible because you’re standing too close to the wall.



CHAPTER FIVE

Stop Auditioning for Love

Validation, approval, rejection, and learning to stop performing for acceptance.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

I've been thinking about how much of my life I've spent auditioning.

The first date where I laughed at everything. The friend group where I turned my opinions into "whatever you guys think." The workplace where I made myself smaller in one room and louder in another depending on who was watching.

I rehearse conversations in the shower. I check how a message will land before I send it, and re-read it three times, and delete the joke.

What exhausts me isn't the performance itself. It's that I never get to find out if I'd be loved without it. I've never taken my hands off the steering wheel long enough to see if the car keeps going.

Somewhere in most of us lives a small, tireless casting director. She watches other people's faces for signs of approval, tweaks the performance accordingly, and never quite lets us know the audition is over. She's the reason we scan a room to see how we're being received, and the reason a friend's two-word reply can ruin our afternoon.

She isn't a villain. She is a survival instinct, trying to protect you from rejection. But she has one serious flaw: she works on the assumption that love is **earned** by being the right version of you for the right audience. And as long as that's the operating belief, you can never relax into being loved, because you'd always be waiting for the review.

Two kinds of validation

Psychologists distinguish between **extrinsic** motivation, doing something for outside reward or approval, and **intrinsic** motivation, doing it because it's meaningful or satisfying in itself. Self-determination theory, developed by Edward Deci and Richard Ryan, suggests people tend to do better and feel better when they act from values and interests of their own rather than mainly to earn approval.

Wanting to be liked is not shallow. We are social animals and belonging is a genuine need. The trouble begins when approval becomes the *only* measure, so that your mood, your decisions and your sense of worth all get handed over to the most recent reaction.

The sign you're auditioning

You may be auditioning if you find yourself doing any of these: adjusting your opinions depending on who's listening; keeping score of who texts first; holding back your real feelings to appear "easygoing"; replaying conversations for evidence of how you came across; feeling disproportionately crushed by small signs of coolness; or being unable to tell whether you like someone, or just like being liked by them.

A STORY

Tessa After the Breakup

Tessa, thirty-three, spent five years with a man who liked her best when she was agreeable, cheerful and slightly less than she was. When he ended things, it wasn't only the relationship she grieved. It was the woman she'd become to keep it. She didn't recognize her own taste in films, food or holiday plans.

For the first two months she performed heartbreak for her friends, then performed healing for her mother. Only when a colleague asked casually, "So what do *you* want to do this weekend?" did she notice she had no idea. She started small: a Saturday morning swim she'd always skipped because he "wasn't a morning person," a solo trip to a town he'd have found boring, a haircut that was frankly worse than the last one but entirely hers.

It wasn't linear. Some nights she reached for her phone to check whether he'd looked at her profile. Some weeks she felt like herself; some weeks she felt like a woman who had lost five years. But she began to notice that the loneliness she'd feared wasn't nearly as bad as the loneliness of being loved for a version of herself.

Rejection is information, not a ruling

Rejection stings because it feels like a verdict on your entire worth. Almost never is it. It's usually information about **fit**: about someone else's readiness, taste, timing, or their own unresolved history. It hurts anyway. Let it. But try not to hold the trial that follows, where you comb through your personality for evidence against yourself.

A steadier response is to ask: *what is this telling me about what I want?* Sometimes the answer is, "Nothing. This was just painful." That is allowed as well.

Being loved without the performance

The paradox is that the quickest route to being truly seen is to risk being disliked. The woman who says, warmly and plainly, "I actually see it differently," gives the people around her something real to relate to. Some will walk away. Those are the people who loved the performance. The ones who stay are loving *you*.

Start small and safe. Give an honest opinion about a film. Say you're tired instead of "fine." Let a text sit for an hour without engineering the perfect reply. Each time, you're not being reckless. You're collecting evidence that you can be a full person and still be welcome.

REAL TALK

Needing to be liked by everyone is a fantastic way to end up known by no one. You cannot be intimately loved while you're still wearing an excellent costume.

GLOW NOTE

The right people don't need the performance. The wrong ones will always want a better show.

REMEMBER THIS

Being disliked by someone is not an emergency. It's simply proof that you exist as a distinct person.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Whose approval do I chase hardest, and what do I imagine would happen if I lost it?
- In which relationship do I edit myself the most?
- What do I do when someone seems displeased with me, and is that response actually helpful?
- What would I do differently this month if being liked weren't a factor at all?

WRITE IT HERE

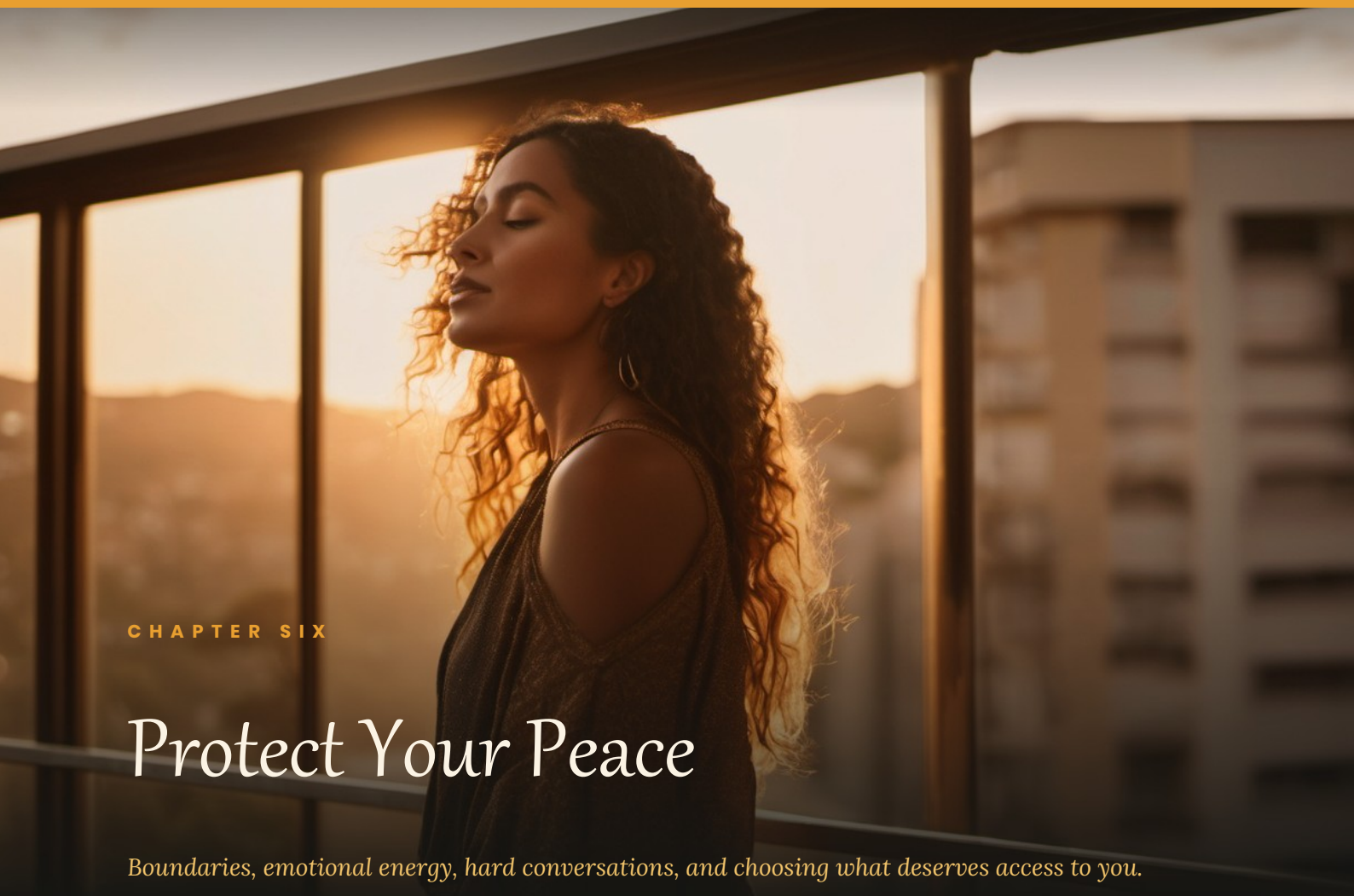
GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Honest Inch

This week, tell **three small truths** you'd normally soften or hide. Not confessions, not confrontations. *I'd rather eat at home tonight. I didn't love that film. I need some quiet after work.* Notice what happens in your body before you say them, and what actually happens afterwards. Write both down.

You're running gentle experiments to test a hypothesis that has ruled your life: *if I'm truthful, I'll be abandoned.* See what the data says.

You can stop auditioning now. The role was never yours to earn. What you wanted all along was not applause but a place at the table, and you get to build one where you're allowed to sit down as yourself, with your real laugh, your real opinions, and your coat still on if you feel like it.



CHAPTER SIX

Protect Your Peace

Boundaries, emotional energy, hard conversations, and choosing what deserves access to you.

FROM THE DIARY

Wednesday, 6:15 a.m.

I woke before the alarm with a knot in my stomach, and it took me a full minute to work out why. Then I remembered: a message from her, unanswered, sitting on my phone like a small hot coal.

I haven't even opened it. I already know the shape of it: a crisis, a request, a tone that suggests I am failing at friendship if I don't drop everything.

Here is what I noticed. My whole body braced for a message. My shoulders were up near my ears. I hadn't breathed out properly in a while.

Nobody has done anything to me this morning. And yet my peace has already been spent, on a text I haven't read.

I think I'm starting to understand that peace is not the absence of problems. It's a resource. And I've been leaving the door open to anyone who wants to withdraw from it.

For a long time I thought "protecting your peace" was a slogan for people with enviable lives. Something you'd embroider on a cushion. It seemed self-indulgent to guard my calm when so many people needed things from me.

Then I noticed how much of my day was spent recovering from things I had permitted. A colleague's sarcasm. A family member's running commentary. A friend's endless emergencies. A group chat that arrives in bursts and never quite lets you rest. None of it was catastrophic. All of it was costly.

Peace is not a luxury. It's the ground your other choices stand on. When it's constantly eroded, you can't think clearly, decide well, or be much use to anyone, including the people you were trying to be available for.

What a boundary actually is

Let's clear up a common misunderstanding. A boundary is **not** a rule you impose on someone else, an ultimatum, or a wall. You can't control what other people do, and trying to is exhausting for everyone.

A boundary is a statement about **what you will do**. "If the conversation turns to insults, I'll leave the room." "I don't reply to work messages after seven." "I'm not available to talk through this again; I can listen for fifteen minutes." The other person is free to respond however they like. You are simply deciding, in advance, how you'll look after yourself in response.

That subtle shift, from *"you must stop"* to *"here's what I'll do"*, is what makes boundaries workable and, frankly, kinder. You're not trying to change anyone. You're refusing to abandon yourself.

Who gets access to you?

Not everyone deserves the same level of access to your time, your confidences, and your emotional energy, and that is not a cruelty. It's how healthy relationships work. Picture a set of circles. In the innermost sit the very few people who've earned your full vulnerability. Next come people you love and trust, with limits. Then acquaintances and colleagues, who get your warmth but not your inner life. Finally, everyone else, who get politeness.

Trouble starts when someone in an outer circle behaves as though they belong in the center, or when you keep handing the keys to someone whose behavior keeps showing you they can't hold them. The reverse is true too: you may have people in the center who could be closer, and you've kept them at arm's length for fear of needing them.



- **INNER CIRCLE**
  The very few who have earned your full vulnerability.
- **TRUSTED**
  People you love and trust, with limits.
- **WARM, NOT INNER**
  Colleagues, acquaintances: warmth without your inner life.
- **POLITE**
  Everyone else: courtesy, and no obligation.

A STORY

Simone and the Friend Who Only Called in Crisis

Simone had known Dana for twelve years. Dana was funny, clever, and had a genuine talent for making a crisis sound like the most urgent thing in the world. Their phone calls ran the same way: ninety minutes about Dana's latest disaster, ten minutes of "anyway, how are you?" that Dana spent half-listening.

Simone loved her. She also began to dread the ringtone. After one particularly draining call, she said, more gently than she felt, *"I want to be there for you, and I've got about twenty minutes tonight. Can we make it a proper catch-up at the weekend?"*

Dana went quiet, then said, "Wow, okay." For two weeks there were no calls. Simone felt a familiar wave of guilt and a new, unfamiliar one of relief. When Dana eventually reached out, the friendship reshaped itself into something smaller and, honestly, more honest: less frequent, less exhausting, occasionally warm. It never quite became what it had been. Simone mourned that a little. She also slept better.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Emotional energy is a finite resource

We tend to treat emotional energy as bottomless, which is why we're so surprised when we run out. Researchers who study burnout describe emotional exhaustion as a core component: the feeling of being drained by demands you don't have capacity to meet. It isn't weakness. It's what happens when output consistently exceeds recovery.

A helpful habit is to notice, after time with someone, how you *feel afterwards*. Lighter? Heavier? Buzzing with anxiety? Your body's post-interaction report is very often more accurate than your explanations for why you "should" enjoy their company.

Hard conversations, gently held

Most of us postpone difficult conversations until resentment has soured them into something explosive. There's a kinder order of operations: **name it early, name it plainly, and name your part.**

Try a simple structure: "*When ___ happens, I feel ___. What I need is ___. Would you be open to that?*" For instance: "When plans change at the last minute, I feel unimportant. I need a little more notice, even by text. Could we try that?" It's not a magic spell, and some people will respond badly. But you'll have said it clearly and without cruelty, which is all you can do.

And if you're about to have one of these conversations, give yourself a few practical advantages: choose a time when neither of you is exhausted, decide beforehand what you actually want as the outcome, and keep one short sentence in your pocket for the moment your nerve wobbles: "*I'm not trying to blame you. I'm trying to be honest.*"

REAL TALK

Some people are not going to like your boundaries, and it will almost always be the people who benefited most from the lack of them. Their displeasure is information. It's not a reason to withdraw the boundary.

GLOW NOTE

Peace is not what you find when everything is calm. It's what you protect when it isn't.

REMEMBER THIS

You can love someone and still decline to be their emotional emergency service.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Who or what reliably drains me, and what have I done so far about it?
- Where do I keep saying "it's fine" when it isn't?
- Which boundary, once stated, would give me the most relief?
- Who in my innermost circle might I be keeping too far away?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Boundary Sentence

Choose **one** recurring situation that costs you peace. Write a single boundary sentence beginning with "I will..." (not "You must..."). For example: *"I will step away from the conversation if voices are raised."* Or: *"I will answer messages between 9 and 5."*

Say it aloud three times, alone. Then find one low-stakes moment this week to actually use it. Afterwards, note how it felt: not whether the other person approved, but whether **you** felt more like yourself.

Protecting your peace is not building a fortress. It's tending a garden: deciding what grows there, what gets pulled out, and who has the gate code. You'll get it wrong sometimes. You'll be too open or too closed. But you'll be practicing what most of us were never taught, the art of staying with yourself while staying in the room.



CHAPTER SEVEN

The Art of Starting Again

Career changes, heartbreak, relocation, failure, and rebuilding after life shifts.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

Boxes in the hallway. A kettle I don't recognize. A kitchen where I keep opening the wrong drawer for the spoons.

Nobody tells you that starting over is mostly logistics and low-grade grief. There's the big cinematic version, suitcase, sunrise, a new chapter, and then there's Tuesday, when you're standing in an unfamiliar supermarket, unable to find the oat milk, and suddenly want your old life so badly your eyes sting.

I don't want my old life. That's the confusing part. I just miss the version of me who knew where everything was.

Tonight, I made tea in a mug I've owned for six years, and it felt like a small piece of home had come along. I keep learning that home is portable. It's just heavier than I thought.

At some point, almost every woman starts over. Not always by choice. A relationship ends, a job vanishes, a plan you'd built your identity around quietly falls apart. Or, sometimes, you choose it: you move cities, change careers, leave a marriage, return to study at forty. And whichever way it arrived, the same peculiar feeling turns up: who am I now that the story I was living has stopped?

We are surprisingly bad at talking about this. We're fluent in the "before" and the "after," the announcement and the triumphant update. But nobody narrates the middle. And the middle is where most of the real work, and most of the fear, lives.

The messy middle has a name

Organizational consultant William Bridges, who wrote about life transitions, described three phases: an **ending**, a **neutral zone**, and a **new beginning.** The neutral zone is the uncomfortable bit in the center: the old thing is over, the new thing hasn't taken shape, and you're left in a kind of open field with nothing to hold.

Most of us try to rush through it. We take the first job offer, start a new relationship too fast, fill the silence with busyness. The neutral zone isn't a waiting room, though. It's where you find out what you want when you're no longer defined by what you *had.* It's slow, and unglamorous, and it can't be skipped, only endured badly or used well.

A STORY

Joanna and the City That Didn't Know Her

Joanna moved cities at thirty-six for a job that looked wonderful on paper. Within six weeks, the excitement had thinned to something quieter and more frightening. She knew no one. She'd gone from being the woman everyone called to the woman who ate cereal for dinner on the sofa and rehearsed small talk in the elevator.

For a while she blamed herself: she was clearly bad at this. Then she read that loneliness after a big move is extremely common, and that it tends to ease not with grand social breakthroughs but with *repeated small contact* in the same places. So she picked three: a Tuesday climbing class, a Saturday market stall where she started buying bread from the same woman, a book club she almost didn't attend.

It took five months before someone texted her, unprompted, to say, "Coming Thursday?" It wasn't the movie version. There were weeks she considered giving up and flying home. But one gray afternoon she caught herself giving directions to a stranger and realized, with a small jolt, that she lived there now.

Grieving what you chose to leave

Here's an unfashionable truth: you can be entirely right to leave something and still mourn it. Grief doesn't only attend deaths. It attends the marriage that didn't last, the career you trained for, the city that shaped you, the person you'd planned to become by now. Pretending you feel only excitement about your fresh start doesn't spare you the sadness. It just sends it underground.

Give yourself permission to hold both. *I'm proud of this leap, and I miss the old life.* Both are true. Neither cancels the other.

When you fail, and you may

Starting again means risking failure in a new arena, often with less credibility and more self-doubt than before. Some new ventures do not work. Businesses close. Relocations fail. A career change turns out to be a mistake. It hurts, and I won't dress it up.

But there's an important difference between a **failed outcome** and a **failed person.** The first is an event: it happened, you learned something, you can adjust. The second is a story you tell yourself, and it's rarely accurate. Ask instead: *What did I learn? What would I do differently? What do I still want?* Then, as gently as you can, make the next decision.

Building a scaffold while you rebuild

In a season of change, structure is the kindest thing you can give yourself. Not a sprawling life overhaul, just **anchors**: a wake-up time, a daily walk, a weekly call to someone who knows you, one small pleasure you protect. These are not trivial. When everything else is uncertain, an anchor tells your nervous system, *some things are still steady.*

Also, start **before you feel ready to be seen.** Attend the class as a beginner. Send the awkward message. Turn up at the event alone. You are allowed to be new. Everyone who looks settled once stood in a doorway feeling exactly as you do now.

REAL TALK

Nobody's "fresh start" looks like the caption. Yours will include days of doubt, unanswered emails, and a supermarket meltdown over oat milk. It's still a fresh start. It's just an honest one.

GLOW NOTE

You are not behind. You are between.

REMEMBER THIS

You have started over before, in ways you barely remember. That is not a small fact. That is a track record.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- What am I actually grieving, underneath the excitement or the fear?
- Which parts of my old self am I taking with me, and which am I setting down?
- What are the three anchors that would make this season steadier?
- What is one small piece of “home” I can carry into the new chapter?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Three Anchors

Choose three small anchors for the next thirty days: **one for your body** (a daily walk, a stretch, an early night), **one for your mind** (ten pages of a book, a journaling habit), and **one for your people** (a weekly call, a regular coffee, a class where the faces repeat).

Write them on a card and put it somewhere you’ll see it. They should be so modest you can do them on a bad day. The goal isn’t optimization. It’s stability while the rest reorganizes.

A fresh start isn’t a blank page. It’s a page that already has your handwriting on it, faded in places, crossed out in others, but yours. You don’t need to erase it to begin again. You just need to keep writing, a little more truthfully than before.



PART THREE

Becoming

Every ordinary Tuesday is a vote for the woman you are becoming.



CHAPTER EIGHT

Become the Woman You Keep Imagining

Vision, identity, habits, personal standards, and the quiet courage of intentional living.

FROM THE DIARY

Tonight I realized...

...that I have a very detailed picture of a woman I keep imagining. She wakes up without dread. She wears things she loves. She has a project that is hers, a body she trusts, a home that feels like an exhale. She says "let me think about it" and means it. She has friends who make her laugh until she cries.

I've been imagining her for years. Every January I tell myself she's coming, as though she's a train.

What I only just noticed is that she isn't going to arrive. She's not waiting somewhere for me to catch up. She's a set of small decisions, and I'm allowed to begin making them, badly, today.

Started with one: I put a plant on the desk. I know. It's a plant. But she'd have a plant.

We all carry a picture of the woman we might yet become. She's rarely a movie star. She's usually startlingly ordinary and quietly radiant: calmer, braver, freer than the woman we are now. And we hold her the way we'd hold a postcard from a country we mean to visit one day.

Vision is powerful. But it has a hidden trap: **imagining a future self can feel so satisfying that it substitutes for building her.** The picture is pleasant, the work is dull, and we stay comfortably in the gap between the two.

The bridge is identity. Not "I want to be a woman who writes," but the small, present-tense decision to act, today, like a woman who does.

Identity is built out of votes

There's a useful idea, popular among people who study habits, that every action is a small vote for the kind of person you're becoming. One evening of writing doesn't make you a writer. But a pile of them starts to tilt the election. You don't need a landslide. You need a majority.

That takes the pressure off. You don't have to *be* her overnight. You only have to cast the next vote in her direction, and let the accumulating evidence do what willpower alone can't.

A STORY

Ines and the Coat

Ines, forty-four, kept a mental image of a woman who walked to work with purpose, wrote in the early mornings, and wore a long camel coat. She was, in Ines's mind, everything Ines wasn't: composed, creative, somehow unhurried.

Ines bought the coat first, which felt like a cheat. But she noticed something curious: wearing it, she walked differently. Slower. Shoulders down. Then she decided the coat woman would surely write for twenty minutes before checking her phone. She tried it for three days, skipped a week, tried again, gave up in the middle of a chaotic month, and returned in spring. The habit never became perfect. She probably wrote on about two days out of three.

But eight months on, she had sixty pages of something. And when a friend asked what she did on her mornings, Ines answered, without thinking, "I write." It was the first time she'd said it without adding "sort of."

BEHIND THE FEELING

How habits actually form

A widely cited 2009 study by Phillippa Lally and colleagues at University College London followed people forming new daily habits and found it took an average of about 66 days for a behavior to feel automatic, with a huge range, from 18 days to 254, depending on the person and the habit. Missing a single day didn't derail the process.

The takeout is gentler than any "21-day" promise: habits are slow, individual, and forgiving. And a simple planning technique, called an *implementation intention*, tends to help: decide in advance

"When X happens, I will do Y." *When I pour my coffee, I'll write one paragraph.* You're borrowing a cue that already exists, rather than relying on motivation.

Standards are not perfection

Being the woman you imagine doesn't mean adopting a punishing set of rules. It means deciding, with clarity, what you will and won't accept in your own life. **Standards are how you treat yourself when no one's checking.** What time you go to bed. Whether you keep small promises. How you speak to yourself after a mistake. Who you allow to speak to you in certain ways.

Perfectionism, by contrast, is a stern parent who never approves. Standards are a friend who believes you're capable of more, and tells you so kindly. Aim for the second.

Four questions to sketch your future woman

How does she feel at the start of an ordinary day? (Not *what does she own*; *how does she feel.*) **What does she spend her attention on**, and what does she let go? **Who is around her**, and how does she behave with them? And finally: **what would she do differently this week?** Not this year. This week.

The last question is the important one. Grand visions are easy. Thursday is where the woman gets made.

REAL TALK

If a goal feels safe to talk about but never appears in your calendar, it isn't a goal. It's a daydream with good branding. There's nothing wrong with daydreams. Just don't mistake one for a plan.

GLOW NOTE

You don't have to become her all at once. You only have to stop waiting for her and start lending her your Tuesdays.

REMEMBER THIS

The woman you're imagining is not a stranger. She is what you look like when you stop postponing yourself.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- How does the woman I keep imagining feel when she wakes up?
- What is one thing she does daily that I could begin in a smaller form?
- What standard would I like to hold for myself that I've been quietly ignoring?
- What am I waiting for permission to become?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Tiny Vote

Choose **one** habit the woman you imagine would do. Shrink it until it takes under five minutes. Attach it to something you already do daily using "When ___, I will ___."

Track it with a simple tick on a calendar for thirty days. If you miss a day, do it the next day without ceremony. The point isn't a perfect streak; it's the direction of the votes.

The woman you keep imagining has been walking toward you all this time, and the cruelest thing you can do is keep her waiting at the door. Open it, badly, in yesterday's clothes, holding a plant. She isn't going to mind.



CHAPTER NINE

Romanticize Your Real Life

Finding beauty in ordinary moments without escaping reality or pretending everything is perfect.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

Something small happened this morning and I want to get it down before it evaporates.

I was making toast, in my socks, half-listening to the radio, thinking about the meeting. And the light hit the kitchen in exactly the right way: low and gold, catching the steam off the kettle. For about four seconds I was completely there. No inbox, no worry. Just butter melting on bread.

I nearly missed it. I nearly walked out the door to get to the next thing.

I think I've been treating my life like a waiting room for the good part. As if the real one starts once I've cleared enough of the to-do list. But the list never clears. And meanwhile the light keeps arriving in the kitchen, and I keep being on my way somewhere else.

"Romanticizing your life" has become a social-media phrase, and there's a cynical way to read it: as another instruction to curate. Candlelit baths, a perfectly placed croissant, a photograph of your own contentment.

That isn't what I mean. I'm talking about something quieter and older: the practice of **paying attention on purpose.** Of noticing the ordinary as if it mattered, because it does. Nothing is being staged, and nothing needs posting. It's simply the refusal to sleepwalk through the only life you're going to have.

It's not escapism

There's an important distinction here. Some ways of "making life beautiful" are really ways of avoiding it: the elaborate aesthetic that hides an unpaid bill, the endless self-improvement project that dodges a difficult conversation. That's decoration as denial.

Real romanticizing sits alongside honesty. You can acknowledge that this month is hard, that you're lonely, that the dishwasher has broken *and* light a candle on the table while you eat toast for dinner. Beauty isn't a distraction from difficulty. It's what keeps you company through it.

A STORY

Wren and the Tuesday Candle

Wren, forty-one, had a job she tolerated and a routine she'd stopped noticing. Weeknights went: tired, takeout, screen, bed. One gray Tuesday she lit a candle she'd been saving "for a special occasion," put a real plate on the table, and ate a very ordinary pasta at a table set for one.

It felt slightly ridiculous. She almost blew it out. But halfway through, she noticed she was actually tasting the food, and that the flat quiet of her evening had turned into something closer to *tenderness.* Nothing in her life had changed. The trash still needed emptying and her inbox was still a small disaster.

She didn't transform into a woman of radiant contentment. Some nights she went straight back to takeout and the sofa, and that was fine too. But she'd found a small lever, a way to say to herself, *this evening counts*, and she found she could reach for it on the days it mattered most.

BEHIND THE FEELING

The science of savoring

Psychologist Fred Bryant, who has studied *savoring* for years, describes it as the capacity to attend to, appreciate and enhance positive experiences. Research on savoring suggests it's a skill that can be practiced, and that pausing to notice and mentally "hold" a pleasant moment tends to be linked with greater wellbeing.

There's also *hedonic adaptation*: our tendency to get used to good things quickly, so that a new home, a promotion, a relationship all lose their shine. Deliberate attention is one gentle counterweight. Not because it makes life better than it is, but because it lets you actually receive what's already there.

Small rituals, not grand overhauls

You don't need a perfect morning routine or a linen-and-eucalyptus kitchen. You need a few small rituals that tell you **you are worth tending to.**

A morning ritual. Five minutes before the phone: open a window, drink something warm, notice the weather. **A midday pause.** Eat one meal without a screen. Look up on your walk. **An evening close.** Light a lamp instead of the overhead light. Put on a record. Wash your face slowly. **A weekly date with yourself.** Not a productivity sprint, a small outing that's yours: a gallery, a long lunch, a walk somewhere unfamiliar.

The point of each is the same: to interrupt autopilot and remind you that you're here.

Make it beautiful, not performative

A useful test: *would I still do this if no one could see?* If the answer is yes, you're romanticizing. If the answer is "not really," you might be curating. Neither is a crime, but only one feeds you.

Also, give yourself beauty **on ordinary days**, not just holidays. The good cups. The nice sheets. The perfume that's been sitting in a drawer for a "special occasion." You are the occasion.

REAL TALK

You can light all the candles you like, but they won't fix a life you're avoiding. Romanticizing works best on top of honesty, not instead of it.

GLOW NOTE

A beautiful life is mostly made of noticing.

REMEMBER THIS

This ordinary day is not a rehearsal for a better one. It's the one you're actually living.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- When did I last feel completely present, and what was I doing?
- What ordinary moment in my day could become a small ritual?
- What am I saving "for a special occasion" that I could use this week?
- Where am I decorating over something I need to face honestly?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Daily Glimmer

For fourteen days, at the end of each day, write down **one small thing that was quietly beautiful**: light on a wall, the way someone said your name, the first sip of tea. Be specific. *"The old man on the bus who gave a stranger his umbrella"* beats *"kindness."*

Notice, by the second week, that you start looking for glimmers *during* the day. That's the skill forming.

A life doesn't have to be extraordinary to be beautiful. It only has to be ***attended to.*** *The most luminous women I know aren't the ones with the best circumstances. They're the ones who let the ordinary light in and stayed still long enough to notice it landing.*



CHAPTER TEN

Money, Independence & the Quiet Power of Choice

Financial confidence, earning, saving, ambition, and understanding that stability can create freedom.

FROM THE DIARY

Thursday, late.

I did something today that I've avoided for two years. I opened my banking app and looked at every account, every subscription, every balance, and didn't close it after four seconds.

I'd built up such a dread of it that I'd stopped looking altogether. I would swipe past the balance the way you'd avoid eye contact with someone you owe an apology.

It turns out the truth was not as bad as the fear. It wasn't wonderful either. But it was knowable. There was an actual number where a monster had been.

I sat there feeling something I hadn't expected: relief, and a very faint, surprising flicker of power. If I can look at it, I can work with it.

Let's talk about money, and let me say up front: I'm not a financial advisor, this isn't financial advice, and your circumstances are your own. But I'm convinced you can't build a life that truly belongs to you without a working relationship with money. Not obsession, not envy, not shame. A working relationship.

For many women, that relationship has been complicated. We were often raised to see money as slightly vulgar, or as something someone else would handle. We were told to be grateful, not ambitious, or ambitious, but quietly. We may have learned to avoid looking, to feel guilty about wanting more, or to tie our sense of worth to our net earnings.

Why this belongs in a book about glow

Because financial dependence, or even just financial *fog*, narrows your choices, and a woman with fewer choices finds it much harder to protect her peace. It's harder to leave a job that drains you, a situation that diminishes you, or a place that no longer fits. Money isn't the meaning of life. But **stability creates options, and options are what freedom is made of.**

That doesn't mean you must earn a fortune to be worthy. It means that increasing your financial confidence, at whatever scale suits your life, is one of the most practical forms of self-respect.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Your "money scripts"

Financial psychologists, including Brad and Ted Klontz, use the term *money scripts* for the largely unconscious beliefs about money we absorb early, often in childhood. Common ones include **avoidance** ("money is bad, or it's not for people like me"), **worship** ("more money will fix everything"), **status** ("my worth is what I own") and **vigilance** ("save everything, never spend").

None of these makes you a bad person. But unexamined, they steer your choices like an autopilot you didn't set. Just noticing which script feels most familiar is a useful first step.

A STORY

Camila Opens the App

Camila, thirty-four, earned a decent salary and could not have told you where it went. She'd never had a budget. She'd inherited from her family a vague conviction that money conversations were rude and that "things always work out." They mostly had, until a car repair on a credit card tipped into a spring of low-level panic.

She began not with a grand plan but with a Saturday morning and a pot of coffee. She listed what came in and what went out, and found a startling amount vanishing into subscriptions, small daily spends, and a gym she didn't use. She built a modest emergency fund, forty dollars a week at first, which felt laughably small. It took eleven months to cover one month of rent.

Then she asked for a raise, rehearsing in the mirror like a teenager. She got about half of what she'd asked for and felt both disappointed and oddly proud. It wasn't a fairy tale. But she'd stopped being someone money happened *to*.

Four steps toward financial confidence

1. Look. Give yourself an honest picture of what comes in, what goes out, what you owe and what you own. It's uncomfortable and it's the foundation of everything. Do it with tea and without judgment.

2. Know your three numbers. What you must spend each month to live. What you'd need to feel safe for a few months if income stopped, often called an *emergency fund*. And what you'd like to save toward that's just for you: your freedom fund, whether it's a course, a deposit, or the ability to leave a bad job.

3. Pay yourself first. Where you can, arrange a small automatic transfer to savings on payday, before you can spend it. The amount matters less than the habit.

4. Learn one thing. Understand your pension or retirement plan. Read about how interest works. Ask a question at the bank. Financial literacy is a skill, not a talent, and it's never too late to acquire it.

Ambition is not a dirty word

Many women feel a quiet embarrassment about wanting to earn more. As though ambition and warmth can't share a house. Wanting more responsibility, a better title, a higher income, or a business of your own is not greedy. It is information about what you're capable of and what you'd like to build.

Negotiating your salary, charging what you're worth, applying for the stretch role: these are skills, and all of them feel uncomfortable at first. Practise out loud. Gather evidence of your results. Ask for the number *and* the reasoning. Getting a "no" is not a catastrophe. Never asking is a decision with a long tail.

REAL TALK

Financial independence isn't about being rich. It's about not having to stay anywhere, with anyone, out of fear of what leaving would cost. Freedom is boring and practical, and it's built on spreadsheets.

GLOW NOTE

Money can't buy your worth, but it can buy you room to choose.

REMEMBER THIS

Looking at the numbers is an act of self-respect, not a sign of failure.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- What did I learn about money growing up, and is it still true?
- What emotion arises when I imagine checking my accounts?
- What would financial freedom actually allow me to do, in specific terms?
- Where might I be underselling myself, or avoiding asking for more?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Saturday Money Date

Set aside sixty minutes this weekend with a hot drink and your accounts. Write down three columns: **What comes in. What goes out. What surprised me.** Find one subscription or habit to cancel, and set up one small automatic transfer, even if it's the price of a coffee.

Repeat monthly. The goal is not perfection; it's familiarity. A number you've looked at is far less frightening than one you haven't.

This chapter is general education only, not financial, tax or legal advice. Consider speaking to a qualified professional about your own situation.

Standing on your own financial feet isn't about turning cold or transactional. It's about being able to say "yes" freely and "no" safely, to stay because you choose to, and to leave when you need to. That is a very quiet, very powerful kind of glow.



CHAPTER ELEVEN

Your Inner Voice Deserves a Better Script

Self-talk, shame, perfectionism, and replacing cruel narration with compassionate honesty.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

I sent an email today with a typo in it. One letter. A missing "e" in a word I have spelled correctly for thirty years.

And for the next three hours, a narrator in my head delivered a full closing statement: sloppy, careless, unprofessional, this is why they don't take you seriously. All that, for one letter.

I don't talk to anyone else like this. If a friend had made that typo, I wouldn't have noticed. If I had noticed, I'd have felt fond of her.

I've been writing the script for my own life in a font so small I forgot it was there. Tonight I read it back for the first time. It's a horror story. And I'm both the author and the only audience.

Every one of us has a narrator. She talks constantly, mostly beneath conscious attention, commenting on what we do, what we should have done, and what it all says about us. If you've never listened closely to her, it's worth trying. Many women are astonished by what they find.

The narrator is not objective. She learned her lines early, from critical adults, hard schools, cruel jokes, and impossible standards, and she has been repeating them ever since, often in the tone of a reasonable, slightly weary authority. That tone is the trick. It makes cruelty sound like common sense.

The usual suspects

Cognitive behavioral therapy, developed from the work of psychiatrist Aaron Beck, describes common **thinking patterns** that distort how we see ourselves. They're worth knowing by name, because naming something is the first step to not obeying it:

All-or-nothing thinking. "If it isn't perfect, it's a failure." **Mind-reading.** "She hasn't replied; she must be annoyed with me." **Catastrophizing.** "This mistake will ruin everything." **Emotional reasoning.** "I feel stupid, so I must be." **The "shoulds."** "I should be further along by now."

Recognizing a pattern doesn't make it vanish. But it changes your relationship to it. *That's catastrophizing* is a very different sentence from *this is the end of the world.*

A STORY

Priya and the Auditor

Priya, forty-two, ran a department of sixty and had been promoted three times in five years. On paper she was a success. Inside, she kept a tireless internal auditor who reviewed every meeting, every decision, every email, and returned a steady stream of findings: *That was mediocre. You sounded unsure. They'll figure it out soon.*

When she finally described this to a mentor, the mentor asked one question: "Would you let a manager speak to your team like that?" Priya laughed, then went quiet. Of course she wouldn't.

She began to notice the auditor's voice, and to answer back in a slightly awkward, deliberate way: *Thank you for the input. Now let's look at the evidence.* It didn't silence the voice. Some weeks it was louder than ever. But she started to hear it as a habit and not a truth, and the difference gave her, for the first time in years, a small amount of breathing room.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Shame, guilt, and self-compassion

Researchers such as June Tangney have drawn a useful distinction: **guilt** says *"I did something bad,"* while **shame** says *"I am bad."* Guilt can motivate repair. Shame tends to make people hide, freeze, or attack themselves, and rarely helps anyone improve.

Psychologist Kristin Neff describes *self-compassion* as having three parts: treating yourself with kindness rather than harsh judgment, recognizing that struggle is part of being human rather than a personal defect, and holding painful feelings in balanced awareness without either suppressing or

drowning in them. Studies suggest self-compassion is associated with greater resilience and motivation, not the lazy complacency many people fear.

THE OLD SCRIPT	THE HONEST, KINDER SCRIPT
"I'm such an idiot."	"That didn't go the way I wanted. I can prepare differently next time."
"Everyone can see I don't belong here."	"I feel out of my depth. That is what growing feels like from the inside."
"I should be further along by now."	"I'm where my choices and circumstances have brought me, and I can choose from here."
"If it isn't perfect, it's worthless."	"Good enough to serve its purpose is a real standard. I can improve it next time."
"They only tolerate me."	"I can't read minds. I can ask, or I can watch how people actually treat me."

Perfectionism is fear with a high-achieving costume

Perfectionism convinces you it's the same thing as excellence. It isn't. Excellence can bend; perfectionism can't. Excellence learns from a mistake; perfectionism holds a tribunal. And perfectionism has a nasty side effect: it often makes you procrastinate, because if it might not be flawless, starting feels dangerous.

The alternative isn't lowering your standards. It's changing the question. Not "is this perfect?" but **"is this good enough to serve its purpose, and what would make it better next time?"** That is still ambitious. It's just survivable.

Compassionate honesty

Here's the nuance: the answer to a cruel inner voice is not relentless cheerfulness. "I'm amazing and everything's wonderful" is another script, and one you won't believe. The kinder alternative is **compassionate honesty**: *I made an error. It was small. I'll fix it. I'm still a competent person.* It acknowledges what happened without inflating it or disowning it.

Compare: "*I'm such an idiot*" with "*That didn't go the way I wanted. I was tired, and I can prepare differently next time.*" The second doesn't lie. It simply refuses to sentence you.

> **REAL TALK**
> **Being hard on yourself is not the same as having high standards. Most of the time it's just a way of getting there first, so no one else can hurt you with it. It doesn't work, and it's exhausting.**

GLOW NOTE

Speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend you're trying to help, not a stranger you're trying to catch out.

REMEMBER THIS

The voice in your head is a habit, not a judge. You are allowed to change the script.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- What is the sentence my inner critic uses most often, and whose voice does it sound like?
- What would I say to a friend who'd just made the same mistake?
- Where is perfectionism keeping me from starting something?
- What is a kinder sentence that is *still honest*?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

Catch, Check, Change

For one week, whenever you notice a harsh inner sentence, do three things. **Catch it:** write it down exactly. **Check it:** ask, *is this a fact, or a feeling dressed as one?* Look for the distortion by name. **Change it:** rewrite it as something you'd say to a friend, honest but kind.

Keep the page. By the end of the week you'll have both a record of the critic and, right beside it, a growing collection of a different voice.

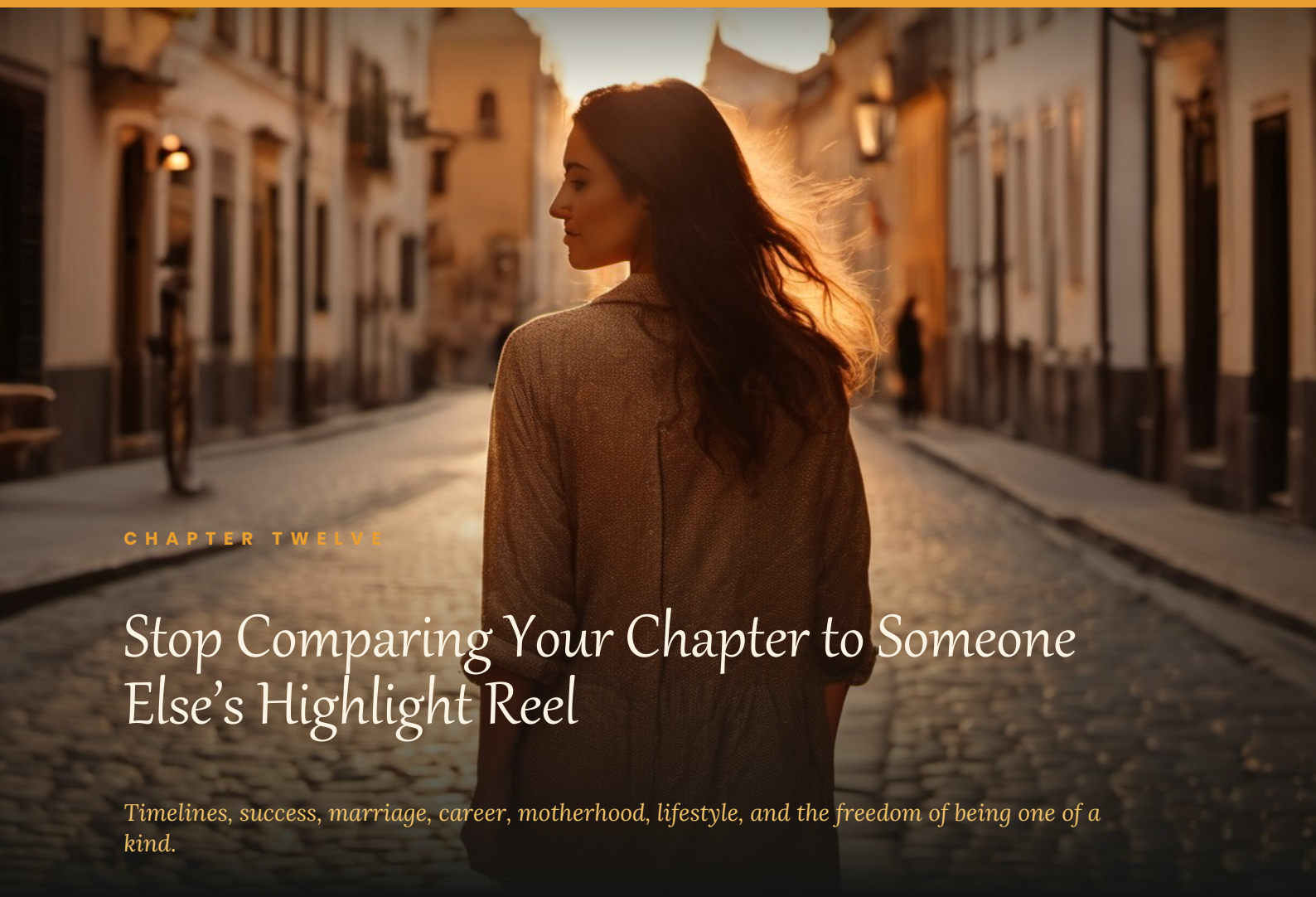
You will not evict the critic entirely, and you don't need to. What you can do is turn down the volume, learn her lines, and gradually write another narrator into the room: one who is on your side, tells you the truth, and has never once called you an idiot for a missing letter.



PART FOUR

Coming Home

The door was never locked. She only had to walk through it.



CHAPTER TWELVE

Stop Comparing Your Chapter to Someone Else's Highlight Reel

Timelines, success, marriage, career, motherhood, lifestyle, and the freedom of being one of a kind.

FROM THE DIARY

Sunday night.

Went to a wedding this weekend. Beautiful. Genuinely. And somewhere between the vows and the speeches, I did the thing I always do: the silent inventory. Who's married. Who's bought a house. Who has a second child on the way. Who looks unbothered by all of it.

And then I sat in the parking lot afterward and realized I'd spent half the reception mentally auditing my life against seventy strangers' Instagram captions.

I'd been having a nice time, too. I think I even laughed. But by the end I felt like I'd sat an exam nobody told me about.

Who set the syllabus? Who decided that by thirty-five I was supposed to have ticked all these boxes? I've never met the examiner. I have absolutely been obeying her.

There's a quiet, ancient scoreboard running in the back of most women's heads. It tracks relationships, careers, houses, children, holidays, bodies, incomes, friend groups, and the general impression of "having it together." And it is a rigged game. Not because the numbers are wrong, but because **you only ever see the other players' highlight reels, and you're comparing them to your own uncut footage.**

Nobody posts the argument in the car on the way to the party. Nobody captions the photo with the six unanswered emails behind it. The gap you feel isn't between your life and theirs. It's between your life and their *edit*.

Timelines are made up

Consider how strange it is that we hold ourselves to a shared schedule at all. Married by a certain age. Established in a career by another. A baby before it's "too late." A house before the market moves. A neat progression, like a train timetable.

Nothing about human lives works this way. Some women find their calling at twenty-three, others at fifty-eight. Some marry twice, others never, and are perfectly at home. Some become mothers at nineteen, some at forty-four, some choose not to, and each of those paths includes joy and grief in proportions no observer can see.

The timeline is a cultural story, not a law of nature. And, like all stories, it's only as true as you agree to keep making it.

A STORY

Three Women at a Reunion

Rachel, Mei and Sofia met for dinner after two years, all thirty-six, all quietly anxious about seeing each other. Rachel had a partner, two young children, and a house she loved; she felt, privately, that her life had shrunk to logistics. Mei ran her own consultancy and traveled constantly; she wondered if she'd missed something everyone else understood. Sofia was recently single, renting, and starting a course; she felt like the only one who hadn't "arrived."

For the first hour, each performed a slightly polished version of her life. Then Rachel, mid-sentence about preschool drop-offs, said, "Honestly, I'd kill for a solo flight." Mei laughed and admitted she'd cried in a hotel lobby the previous week, longing to be someone's Sunday. Sofia, surprised, said she'd envied both of them all evening.

It didn't fix anything. Nobody swapped lives. But a small knot loosened in each of them, and the conversation turned to the honest kind. They left more tired and more tender than they'd arrived, which, Sofia decided on the way home, was a far better outcome than being impressive.

BEHIND THE FEELING

What comparison actually does

Research on social media and wellbeing is mixed and still evolving, but a consistent theme is that *how* people use it matters: passive scrolling and constant upward comparison tend to be associated with

feeling worse, while active connection, such as messaging a friend or engaging with something you genuinely care about, is less so.

The takeout isn't that you must throw your phone in the sea. It's that you have more control than it feels like, and that awareness of the mechanism, *I'm comparing my behind-the-scenes to her trailer*, weakens its grip.

Envy is a compass

Here's a small reframe that many women find liberating: **envy isn't always a character flaw. It's often a pointer.** When you feel a twist of envy, it's worth asking not "what's wrong with me?" but "what exactly am I looking at?" Often it isn't the person's whole life you want. It's one specific thing: the freedom, the closeness, the creative work, the ease.

Get precise. Envy of a friend's engagement might really be *I want to feel chosen.* Envy of a colleague's promotion might be *I want my work recognized.* Once you've found the specific desire underneath, you can decide whether it's something you actually want, and what you might do about it. Envy stays vague and corrosive when you don't look at it. Looked at directly, it often turns into information.

Define your own scoreboard

Ask: **"If nobody could see my life, what would I want in it?"** Not what looks good, what feels good, day to day. A slower morning. A creative project. A friend group where you can be quiet. A career that grows, or a career that stays small and leaves room for other things.

Then write your own definition of a meaningful life, in your own words, and treat it as a living document. It may change. Yours might include marriage and children or neither; a large ambition or a modest, well-tended one. The only requirement is that **it's yours.**

REAL TALK

Some of the women you envy would swap places with you in a heartbeat, for reasons you can't see from where you're standing. That doesn't make their life less good or yours more so. It just means no one is watching your whole story.

GLOW NOTE

Your timeline is not late. It's yours.

REMEMBER THIS

Nobody is living the life you think they are. Comparison is the art of losing to a fiction.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Whose life do I compare mine to most, and what specifically do I envy?
- What "deadline" am I obeying that no one actually set for me?
- What does a meaningful life look like *to me*, in ordinary daily detail?
- What in my life would I be proud of if nobody ever saw it?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Envy Compass

The next time you feel a pang of envy, pause and write three lines. **Who or what triggered it? What exactly am I wanting? Is there a small step toward it that's mine to take?**

After a month, read them all. You'll likely find a pattern, a handful of real desires that keep resurfacing. That's your compass. Follow it, and leave the scoreboard where you found it.

Your chapter is not a draft of somebody else's. It has its own pacing, its own plot twists, its own strange and unrepeatable weather. You cannot read the whole book from where you stand. And that is not a flaw in the story. It is what makes it a story worth being inside.



CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Woman You Become When You Choose Yourself

Self-respect, standards, courage, and becoming intentional about the people you let close.

FROM THE DIARY

Dear Me,

I've been trying to work out why I'm so tired in my relationships, and tonight I think I found it.

I am extremely good at being needed. I'm the one people call. The one who knows what to say, who fixes, who arrives. It is one of the loves of my life, being useful to people.

But if I stopped, for a month, if I went quiet and needed nothing and offered nothing, I genuinely don't know who would call to ask how I was. Not out of fear. Just... out of not knowing what to do with me when I'm not solving something.

I'm not sure whether that's a fact about them or a fact about how I've arranged things. I suspect it's mostly the second. And I'm quite sure I've been calling "needed" by the name of "loved" for a very long time.

There's a moment, often after a difficult year, when a woman quietly decides she's going to stop leaving herself behind. It's rarely dramatic. It might be a Tuesday, or a conversation, or the sudden clarity of a good night's sleep. But something in her posture changes, and the people around her, over the following months, can feel it.

This chapter is about what happens next: the shift from *surviving other people's needs* to **choosing yourself**, and the kind of woman who tends to emerge from that choice. Not colder. Not harder. Simply more *present*, because she's finally there.

Choosing yourself isn't selfish, and it isn't isolation

Let's get the fear out of the way. "Choosing yourself" is sometimes mistaken for abandoning everyone else, becoming self-absorbed, or deciding relationships are a burden. It's none of those things. It's the recognition that **you are a person in your own life, not just a supporting character in everyone else's.**

The woman who has chosen herself still loves generously. But she gives from choice, not compulsion. She has preferences, and states them. She has a limit, and honors it. She can be alone without panic and together without disappearing.

A STORY

Hannah Learns the Difference

Hannah, thirty-seven, thought of herself as the person her friends and family relied on. She listened for hours. She lent money, drove people to airports, sat with them through breakups. She was, by common agreement, the best.

Then she had a long, unpleasant winter of flu and burnout, and for six weeks she couldn't be that person. She noticed who checked in. A few people did, warmly, and one old friend arrived with soup and stayed to watch a terrible film. Several others went quiet, not out of cruelty; they simply didn't know how to relate to a Hannah who wasn't giving something.

She was hurt, and then thoughtful. She realized she'd trained the people around her to expect a certain service, and that some relationships were built almost entirely on it. She didn't drop them. But she began cultivating the friendship with the soup, letting people see her tired and unimpressive and needing something. Some relationships got closer. A couple faded. She grieved both, and decided both were information.

BEHIND THE FEELING

Being needed vs. being loved

Being needed is about *function*: what you provide. Being loved is about *presence*: who you are. The two can overlap beautifully, but they are not the same, and many women, especially those raised to be helpful, quietly confuse them.

A useful test is to notice how you feel when you're **not** useful to someone. Is the relationship still warm? Do you feel welcome, or as though you owe something? Healthy closeness has room for your ordinary, unproductive, slightly cranky self.

Standards: what you will and won't accept

Self-respect shows up most clearly in what you tolerate. It's your **personal standard**: the minimum you accept in how you're treated, and in how you treat yourself. It isn't a list of demands on other people; it's a description of what you'll no longer participate in.

A woman with clear standards doesn't hold a grudge or a tribunal. She simply notices. *When someone speaks to me with contempt, I leave. When plans are repeatedly canceled, I stop arranging them. When I'm not sure I'm wanted, I ask, and I believe the answer.* The standard isn't punishment. It's a form of self-care that happens to be visible to others.

Friendships between women, on purpose

Don't underestimate the quiet power of good female friendships. Not the ones based on competition, gossip, or shared complaints alone, but the ones where you can say something true and be met with, *me too*, or *tell me more*. Those friendships are a form of wealth.

They usually need tending. Invite first. Reach out without an agenda. Say the vulnerable thing a little earlier than feels comfortable. Celebrate people's wins without measuring them against your own. And where a friendship has become one-sided, consider whether an honest conversation, or a quieter drift, would serve you both better.

REAL TALK

Some people will only ever love the version of you that costs them nothing. Discovering that hurts. It also clears the shelf for people who want the actual woman.

GLOW NOTE

Self-respect is quiet. It sounds like "no, thank you," and it looks like leaving the room without slamming the door.

REMEMBER THIS

You are not a service. You are a person, and the right people will want to know you, not just use you.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- In which relationships do I feel valued for who I am, and in which for what I do?
- What is one standard I'd like to hold that I've been quietly compromising?
- Who in my life could I let see me less put-together?
- What kind of friend do I want to be, and what kind do I want around me?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

Your Five Non-Negotiables

Write five short sentences beginning **"I no longer accept…"** or **"I will always…"** Keep them concrete: *I no longer accept being spoken to with contempt. I will always tell the truth about how I feel, even quietly. I will always keep one evening a week for myself.*

Fold the page and keep it somewhere private. Read it monthly. Notice which ones you're already living, and which ones ask for a little courage. You don't need to announce them. You just need to start behaving as if they're true.

When you choose yourself, you don't stop being generous, warm, or kind. You just stop being available for things that cost you the woman you've fought to come back to. And, in a lovely irony, the people who truly love you find there's more of you to love, not less.



CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Your Glow Is a Lifestyle

Building sustainable habits around wellbeing, relationships, work, health, appearance, finances, rest, and learning.

FROM THE DIARY

Sunday, 8:10 p.m.

Fell into a familiar trap this weekend: a grand overhaul. New planner, new gym plan, new sleep schedule, a color-coded meal chart, a vow to wake at five. I even bought a smaller water bottle for reasons that made sense at the time.

By Wednesday it will be a graveyard.

I think I'm addicted to the beginning. The fresh notebook feeling. The fantasy of a totally reformed woman arriving on Monday.

What I actually need is something much duller and more durable. Not a transformation. A pace. Something I could keep doing on a bad Thursday, with a headache, in a mood.

Tonight I've crossed out the five a.m. thing and kept only one line on the list: go to bed by eleven. That feels like something a real woman would actually do.

There's a difference between a glow-up and a glow. A glow-up is an event: a before and after, a dramatic season of self-improvement, usually followed by relapse and a sense of failure. A glow is a lifestyle: the accumulated result of ordinary, sustainable decisions that steadily make you feel more like yourself.

The trouble with most self-improvement is that it's built for the best version of you on your best day. Real life is run by the woman you are on your average Wednesday, tired, distracted, running late. If a habit can't survive her, it won't last.

Build a floor, not a ceiling

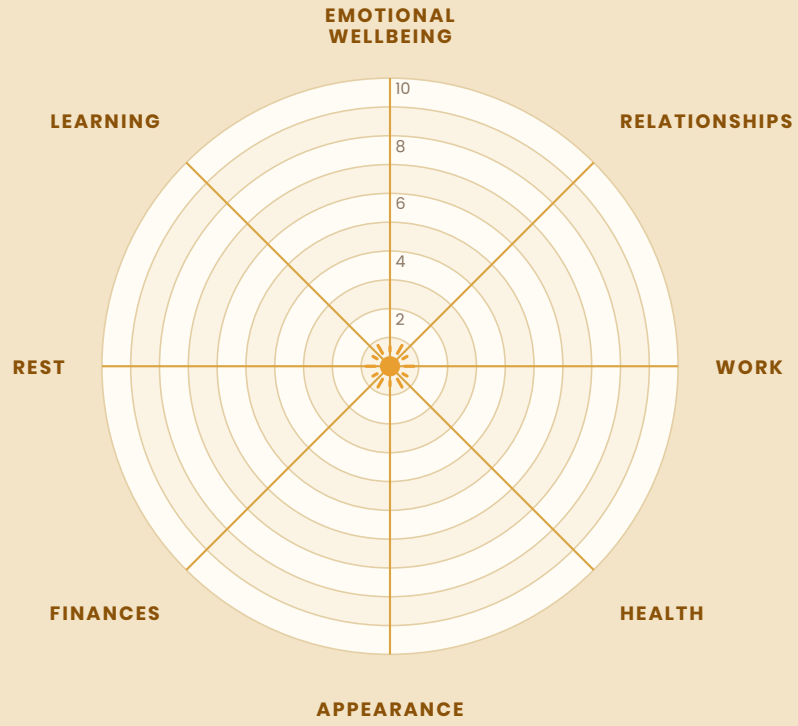
Instead of aiming for a perfect routine, design a **minimum glow day**: the smallest version of self-care you could do even on a terrible day. Perhaps it's a glass of water, ten minutes of fresh air, one real meal, one kind message, and bed by a decent hour. That's your floor. Ambitious days are a bonus. Everything above the floor is a gift, and the floor itself is enough to keep you connected to yourself.

Consistency isn't about intensity. It's about not disappearing.

The Glow Wheel

I like to think of a well-tended life in eight parts. **Emotional wellbeing:** how you process feelings, and who you talk to. **Relationships:** the depth of your connections. **Work:** whether it uses you well, and vice versa. **Health:** movement, food, sleep, and the medical care you need. **Appearance:** how you look after yourself, on your terms. **Finances:** your sense of security. **Rest:** genuine recovery. **Learning:** your curiosity in motion.

No one scores ten across the board, and no one's meant to. The value of the wheel is to notice which spoke is flattest right now, then nudge it a single notch, not to fix your entire life in a weekend.



Shade each spoke from the center outward: 1 = running on empty, 10 = thriving.

A STORY

Dara and the Closed Laptop

Dara, thirty-two, had taken pride in being the person who was always "on." She answered emails at midnight, took calls on holiday, and quietly considered rest a luxury for less ambitious people. Then, after a long run of eighteen-hour days, she found herself crying in a supermarket over a wrong brand of yogurt, and knew something had to give.

Her first attempt at rest was terrible. She spent a Saturday "relaxing" while feeling guilty, checking her phone and mentally listing everything she was failing to do. It took weeks to learn that rest is partly a skill: that it wasn't about doing nothing while dreading everything, but about *actually letting the day be over*. She started with a rule so small it felt silly: laptop closed by seven, phone in another room by ten.

Some evenings she broke it. A deadline is a deadline. But over the winter she noticed she was thinking more clearly, snapping less, and, to her surprise, doing better work in fewer hours. Rest hadn't made her lazy. It had given her back her edges.

Rest is not a reward

We often treat rest as something to be earned after enough productivity, and then feel too guilty to enjoy it. But rest isn't a prize; it's **maintenance.** Sleep, in particular, is a foundation for mood, memory and stress tolerance, and no supplement or routine really makes up for chronic shortage. (If you're struggling with persistent sleep problems or exhaustion, do see a health professional; this isn't a substitute for medical advice.)

One popular framework suggests that rest comes in several kinds: physical, mental, emotional, social, creative, sensory. Whether or not you use that particular list, the insight is useful: **different tiredness needs different rest.** After a day of screens, you may need quiet more than sleep. After a day of people, you may need solitude. After a week of routine, you may need play.

Small, repeatable, kind

For each part of the wheel, choose one tiny action you could reliably do. **Emotional wellbeing:** five minutes of writing, three evenings a week. **Relationships:** a weekly call to someone who matters. **Work:** shut down at a set time. **Health:** a daily walk. **Appearance:** one item of clothing or self-care you actually enjoy. **Finances:** the monthly money date. **Rest:** a screen-free hour before bed. **Learning:** one chapter, one podcast, one class.

Notice that none of these will make an impressive social-media post. That's the point. A lifestyle doesn't look dramatic from the outside. It looks like a woman who is, quietly and steadily, okay.

REAL TALK

If your self-care routine has become another list you're failing at, it isn't self-care anymore. It's a second job with worse pay.

GLOW NOTE

The best habit is the one you can still do on a bad day.

REMEMBER THIS

You are allowed to be tired. Rest is not a detour from your life. It's part of it.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- Which part of my Glow Wheel is flattest right now, and what does it need?
- What is my minimum glow day: the floor I'd like to maintain even when things are hard?
- Where do I treat rest as something I have to earn?
- What habit have I been trying to force that I could shrink by half?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

Your Glow Wheel

Rate each of the eight areas from 1 to 10, honestly, in the wheel above (or on paper). Circle the **lowest** one. Choose a single action, small enough to do in ten minutes, that would move it up by **one** point this month.

Revisit the wheel in four weeks. Shift focus to whichever area is now flattest. Over a year, that quiet rotation is far more powerful than any January overhaul.

The woman who glows isn't the one with the perfect routine. She's the one who keeps returning to herself: after the bad week, the busy season, the small collapse. She has stopped searching for a system that will hold her forever, and has learned instead how to gently, and without drama, pick herself up.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

A Letter to the Woman I Am Becoming

Self-acceptance, hope, courage, and the ongoing work of continuing to evolve.

FROM THE DIARY

The last page of the diary, for now.

Dear Me,

I'm going to write you a letter. You're going to read it in a year, or five, on some tired evening when you've forgotten how far you've come. I know you. You'll skim the good parts and focus on what's left undone.

So here is a letter that tells you, in advance, what you're likely to forget.

A LETTER TO OPEN IN A YEAR

Dear Woman I Am Becoming,

I want to start by saying thank you. Not for the things you've achieved, though I hope there have been some, but for the quieter work: the mornings you got up anyway, the honesty you found when a lie would have been easier, the times you chose yourself without an audience.

I hope you have learned to hear your own voice again. I hope you know what you like, what you want, and what you will no longer accept. I hope you've said no without writing a page of apology, and yes without a knot in your stomach.

I hope you've stopped waiting to be chosen, and started choosing.

I know that you won't be finished. There will be new losses, new versions of the old doubts, mornings when the critic is louder than the whole rest of you. I hope you meet those days with patience instead of surprise. You were never going to be a woman for whom the hard days stopped. You were always going to be a woman who learned how to walk through them without abandoning herself.

Please keep being generous, but from a full cup. Please keep your friendships and your boundaries, and remember the two are on the same side. Please look after your body as if it belonged to someone you love, because it does. Please keep noticing the light in the kitchen.

Please forgive the woman who came before you. She was doing her best with the maps she had, and she got you here.

And on the days when you feel like a beginner again, and you will, remember that beginners are simply people at the start of a good story.

I'm proud of you. Not because you're perfect. Because you stayed.

With love, from a night in the middle of the road,

Me

What this final chapter asks of you

Write your own. The most powerful thing you can do with this book is put it down and write a letter to the woman you're becoming, and then, somewhere private, read it aloud.

Say what you hope. Say what you forgive. Say what you promise to keep doing when the enthusiasm fades. Write the truth, not the glossy version. The woman reading it in a year won't need to be impressed. She'll need to be *remembered.*

BEHIND THE FEELING

Why letters help

Writing about your own experience, in expressive or reflective ways, has been studied by psychologists such as James Pennebaker, whose research suggests that structured personal writing can help some people make sense of difficult experiences. It's not a treatment, and it won't suit everyone, but for many people the act of putting things into words gives them shape and distance, which is often what a swirling feeling needs.

GLOW NOTE

You don't have to have it all figured out to have it all in front of you.

REMEMBER THIS

You have been becoming this woman all along. This book only turned the light on.

JOURNAL MOMENT · ASK YOURSELF

- What do I want to thank my past self for?
- What do I hope for the woman I am becoming?
- What will I need to hear on a hard day a year from now?
- What am I finally ready to forgive myself for?

WRITE IT HERE

GLOW PRACTICE · TRY THIS

The Letter

Take a sheet of good paper. Write a letter to yourself to be opened **one year from today**. Include: what you're proud of, what you're still learning, three promises, and one sentence you want her to remember. Seal it, date the envelope, and put it somewhere you'll find it. Then set a reminder.

Not the woman you were, and not the polished stranger you keep imagining. The woman in between, learning, fumbling, extending her hand toward the light: she is the real one. She always was. And the more you love her, the more clearly she glows.



EPILOGUE

Keep Glowing, Even on the Days You Don't Feel Like It

A small manual for the dim days.

FROM THE DIARY

Tuesday. Flat, gray, ordinary.

No epiphany today. Woke up with a heavy head and a very plausible case for staying in bed. Snapped at someone. Ate lunch over the sink. Felt for about an hour as though every page I've written in this diary was written by someone else.

And then, around four, I did something small: I opened the window, made tea, and stood there. Not a ritual. Not a breakthrough. Just: this is the gap where I decide whether to abandon myself or not.

Today I didn't. That's all. It's enough.

Here's what nobody tells you at the end of a book like this: **the days you don't feel like glowing will keep coming.** *They're not evidence of failure. They're the weather. You'll have bad weeks, relapses into old habits, mornings when the critic's voice is back at full volume and the woman you've been building seems to have wandered off.*

That doesn't undo anything. It's not a return to zero. Growth doesn't move in a straight line, and it isn't lost when you dip. You keep the insights. You keep the practices. You keep, more than anything, the *knowing* that there is a way back.

A small manual for the dim days

Lower the bar, don't leave. Go back to your minimum glow day. Water, air, food, one kind thing, bed.

Name what's happening. *I'm tired. I'm overwhelmed. The critic is loud.* Naming turns a mood into a fact you can work with.

Do one thing that's evidence. A short walk. A message to a friend. One line in the diary. Small proof beats large intentions.

Remember the pattern. You've had days like this before, and they passed. Trust your own track record.

Ask for help. From a friend, a family member, or a professional. If low mood is persistent, heavy, or frightening, please speak to a doctor or a qualified mental health professional. Asking for support is not a step backward. It is one of the most self-respecting things a person can do.

You don't need to glow every day. You need to keep coming home.

What it looks like to keep going

It looks unremarkable, mostly. A woman who says "let me think about it." A woman who leaves the party at ten because she wants to. A woman who looks at her bank account without flinching, wears the good perfume on a Tuesday, and lets the friend who's only ever taken finally hear "not this time."

It looks like a woman who sometimes gets it wrong and doesn't go to war with herself about it. It looks like ordinary life, with the volume of self-abandonment turned down a notch.

And, every so often, in a kitchen at four o'clock, in a store window, in the face of a friend who says "you seem different," it looks like a woman catching sight of herself and thinking, with a small, private astonishment: *oh. There you are.*

REMEMBER THIS

Keep glowing, not because it's easy, but because it's yours.

Thank you for spending these evenings with me. Now go and put the kettle on.

READ IT ALOUD. RETURN TO IT OFTEN.

Glow Diary Manifesto

I CHOOSE to be honest with myself before I am impressive to anyone else.

I CHOOSE the pause before the automatic yes.

I CHOOSE to tell the small truth, even when my voice shakes.

I RELEASE the version of me who was easy to live with and hard to know.

I RELEASE the timelines I never agreed to.

I RELEASE the belief that my worth is measured in usefulness.

I PROTECT my peace as though it were the ground I stand on.

I PROTECT the hours that belong to me.

I PROTECT my body from contempt, including my own.

I ALLOW myself to begin as a beginner.

I ALLOW rest without earning it.

I ALLOW people to be disappointed, and myself to survive it.

I NO LONGER audition for a place at the table I am already sitting at.

I NO LONGER narrate my life in a voice I would not use on a friend.

I NO LONGER compare my whole chapter with someone else's highlight.

I AM LEARNING to keep the promises I make to myself.

I AM BECOMING a woman with money, choices, and doors that open from my side.

I AM BECOMING the woman I kept imagining, one ordinary Tuesday at a time.

I AM NOT waiting to be found. I am coming home.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

Dear reader,

If you have reached this page, then we have spent a good many evenings together, and I feel I owe you the truth about why I wrote this.

I wrote it because I kept meeting women, in cafés, in messages, in the small confessions people make at the end of a long dinner, who were quietly exhausted from being everything to everyone and had lost track of the one person they couldn't afford to lose. They were not broken. They were extraordinary. They were also tired, and unsure where their own light had gone.

I wanted to write the book I would have wanted to find on my own pillow on one of those nights: not a lecture, not a formula, not another list of ways to improve. Just a warm, honest voice saying, *I know. It's not just you. And you don't have to become someone else.*

Because that has been the quiet lie underneath so much advice for women: that we must transform, reinvent, upgrade, glow up, become the polished stranger who finally deserves her own approval. I don't believe it. I believe the woman you're searching for has been with you every step, waiting patiently for you to stop leaving her behind.

I hope you take from this book whatever is useful and forgive the rest. I hope you write in the margins. I hope you disagree with me somewhere and find your own sentence to replace mine. And I hope, on some ordinary evening a long way from now, you find yourself doing something entirely small, laughing without checking who noticed, saying no without an apology, standing in your own kitchen light, and realize you feel like yourself.

That is the whole point. Not a new woman. Not a better one. Just *you*, no longer abandoned.

> You do not have to become a different woman.
> You only have to stop abandoning the woman you already are.

With warmth, and with faith in you,

Zirlandia Milkovic

I don't need to find my glow.
I need to come home to myself.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Zirlandia Milkovic writes warm, honest books for women who are ready to stop performing and start living: on confidence, boundaries, money, and the slow, steady work of becoming yourself.

Her writing is built on a simple conviction: that growth does not require a new personality, only more honesty, kinder self-talk, and better choices repeated over time. *Glow Diary* is her most personal book, written as a series of evening conversations between one woman and another.